

Foreign-Policy Foundations and Strategic Autonomy — Premium Solved PYQ Workbook

UPSC General Studies Paper II · International Relations · Topic 01 · Companion to
Foreign-Policy-Foundations_Complete-Learning-Session_2026-08-10.md

Date: 10 August 2026 · Coverage: both exam stages (Prelims GS-I and Mains GS-II) · Level: Medium-to-hard,
calibrated to actual UPSC difficulty

Evidence key. ✓ Fact — from an official UPSC question paper, an official answer key, an authored knowledge file, a local OCR-searchable source book, or a source fetched live during this session. △ Inference — analytical, for exam use. ? Not verifiable from the sources available — flagged, never filled. 📄 Current anchor, with its source class stated.

What this workbook contains

- 1. An explicit, methodologically stated PYQ ownership audit covering GS-II Mains 2018–2025 and Prelims GS-I 2018–2026.*
- 2. Every directly topic-owned verified PYQ found — and an honest statement of the count when the count is zero.*
- 3. A clearly separated section of closest verified application PYQs, each with its true owning topic named, included only where the foundations vocabulary is genuinely required.*
- 4. Exactly 32 original hard MCQs, static and current-application, with a strict $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C \rightarrow D$ key rotation repeated eight times, four plausible options each, and a detailed explanation plus trap logic for every one.*
- 5. Remedial practice targeting the two error families this topic exists to eliminate: classification/status errors, and current-affairs overclaiming.*
- 6. Exactly 10 original solved Mains questions — 3×10 marks (150 words), 4×15 marks (250 words), 3×20 marks (300–350 words) — each with demand decoding, a full model answer and a top-answer checklist.*
- 7. A GS-II International Relations high-score answer protocol.*
- 8. A final rapid revision matrix.*

Sources of record for this workbook.

✓ *Official UPSC papers read directly from books/: mains/02 UPSC 2024 Paper-II.pdf; mains/UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 2.pdf; more_previous_papers/GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-II.pdf (2018), Gen_St_P2.pdf (2020), QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-II.pdf (2019), QP-CSM-21-GENSTUDIESPAPER-II-110122.pdf, QP-CSM-22-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-II-190922.pdf, QP-CSM-23-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-II-180923.pdf.*

✓ *Prelims GS-I papers: 2018 (QP-CSP-18-GS-I-C.pdf), 2020 (CSP_2020_GS_Paper-1.pdf), 2021 (QP-CSP-21-GeneralStudiesPaper-I-121021.pdf), 2023 (QP_CS_Pre_Exam_2023_280523.pdf), 2024, 2025 and 2026 (prelima question paper answers/*-GS1-Set A.pdf).*

✓ *Official provisional answer keys: Ans-2024-GS1.pdf, Ans-2025-GS1.pdf, Ans-2026-GS1-Provisional.pdf.*

✓ *Read-only provenance ledger: PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.*

✓ *Authored knowledge: International-Relations/basic/01, advanced/01, 00_Master-Framework.md; Polity/basic/National-Integration-and-Foreign-Policy.md; World-History/basic/15 Cold-War-and-International-Relations.md.*

✓ *Local books: Sikri, Challenges and Strategy; Tharoor, Pax Indica; Bipan Chandra et al., India After Independence 1947–2000.*

📄 *Live fetch/search on 10 August 2026 for the window 10 February – 10 August 2026.*

PART I — PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT

I.1 Method

△ The audit was conducted as follows, and the method is stated because the conclusion depends on it.

- STEP 1 Open every official GS-II Mains paper 2018-2025 that is present in books/ and extract the printed English text.
-> 8 papers . 20 questions each . 160 questions examined.
- STEP 2 Open every available official Prelims GS-I paper 2018-2026 and search the full text for the topic's defining vocabulary:
panchsheel . non-align/nonalign . Bandung . strategic autonomy . multi-align . NAM . Global South . SAGAR . Neighbourhood First . Act East . BRICS . Quad . G20 . SCO . IMEC . BIMSTEC . SAARC . ASEAN . UNCLOS . Indo-Pacific . I2U2 . IORA . ITEC . IBSA . treaty . United Nations Security Council.
- STEP 3 Cross-check against the read-only provenance ledger
_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md, which records 24 GS-II International Relations rows for 2018-2023 with their owning topic files.
- STEP 4 Classify each hit:
OWNED = the question's SUBJECT is this topic
APPLIED= the question's subject is another topic, but the foundations vocabulary is genuinely REQUIRED
UNRELATED
- STEP 5 For every Prelims item retained, verify the key against the OFFICIAL answer-key PDF. If the key cannot be verified from a local official source, OMIT the question. Do not reconstruct a key from memory or from a coaching aggregator.

I.2 Result — directly topic-owned Mains PYQs

✓ COUNT: ZERO.

△ Across the eight official GS-II Mains papers from 2018 to 2025 — 160 questions — no question names strategic autonomy, non-alignment, multi-alignment, Panchsheel, the Non-Aligned Movement, Article 51, or India's foreign-policy doctrine as its subject.

✓ This finding is independently corroborated by the authored knowledge files, which state it in terms: "No GS-II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names 'strategic autonomy,' 'non-alignment' or 'multi-alignment' as the framing device. State this honestly rather than force-fitting an unrelated PYQ." This workbook extends that audit backwards to 2018 and reaches the same conclusion.

△ This is stated as a finding, not as an apology. A candidate who is told that this topic has "many PYQs" has been misinformed and will waste preparation time hunting for them. The correct inference is the opposite of neglect: the topic is assumed by every IR question rather than asked by any, which makes it the highest-leverage and least-visible content in the GS-II IR syllabus.

I.3 Result — directly topic-owned Prelims PYQs

✓ COUNT: ZERO verifiable.

△ Keyword searches across the available official Prelims GS-I papers for 2018, 2020, 2021, 2023, 2024, 2025 and 2026 returned no hit for Panchsheel, non-alignment, Bandung, strategic autonomy, multi-alignment, NAM, SAGAR, Neighbourhood First or Act East.

? A separate, honest limitation. Two Prelims GS-I questions from 2026 are adjacent enough to have been considered — Q64 (international conventions not ratified by India) and Q78 (outcomes of the German Chancellor's January 2026 visit, including two MoUs, a bilateral Indo-Pacific dialogue mechanism and an honorary consulate). Both would be excellent teaching material on ratification status and MoU status. They are omitted from this workbook because the locally held official key, Ans-2026-GS1-Provisional.pdf, is an image-only PDF with no extractable text layer, so the official answer cannot be verified from a local official source. △ Per the honesty rule, a question whose key cannot be verified is omitted rather than answered from inference.

I.4 Result — closest verified APPLICATION PYQs

⚠ The following questions are NOT owned by this topic. Each is owned by another International Relations topic file, named explicitly below. They are included because each is unanswerable at a high standard without the foundations vocabulary — interest heads, level selection, instrument status, the alliance/partnership distinction, the autonomy–dependence trade-off, or the announcement–delivery discipline.

#	Year	Paper · Q	Marks · Words	Subject as printed	True owning topic	Foundations content genuinely required
M-1	2024	GS-II · Q9	10 · 150	The West "fostering" India against China's supply-chain and strategic dominance	advanced/03_India-China-Major-Powers-and-Resilient-Supply-Chains	Being fostered ≠ autonomy; co-option vs pole; partnership ≠ alliance
M-2	2025	GS-II · Q19	15 · 250	Energy security as "the dominant kingpin of India's foreign policy"	advanced/06_West-Asia-Energy-Security-and-Connectivity	Resources interest head; leverage–vulnerability duality; diversification
M-3	2025	GS-II · Q10	10 · 150	Waning globalisation; the post-Cold-War world as a site of sovereign nationalism	advanced/11_Globalisation-Trade-Agreements-and-External-Policy-Effects	Sovereignty-first determinant; rule-shaping; sanctions-obligation gap
M-4	2020	GS-II · Q19	15 · 250	The Quad "shifting from an alliance to a trade bloc"	advanced/10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings	Quad is a non-treaty coalition — the stem's premise must be corrected
M-5	2019	GS-II · Q19	15 · 250	India's image as leader of the oppressed and marginalised nations	advanced/08_Global-South-and-Development-Partnering	Anti-colonial inheritance; principle–interest complementarity; VOGSS
M-6	2023	GS-II · Q19	15 · 250	NATO expansion and a stronger US–Europe partnership "works well for India"	advanced/10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings	Alliance vs partnership; autonomy under alignment pressure
M-7	2021	GS-II · Q10	10 · 150	The USA facing an existential challenge from China	advanced/03_India-China-Major-Powers-and-Resilient-Supply-Chains	Balancing / bandwagoning / hedging triad; multipolarity
M-8	2025	GS-II · Q20	15 · 250	UN reform unresolved amid East–West imbalance	advanced/12_UN-and-International-Institutions-Global-Governance	Rule-shaping interest; institutional-voice; multipolarity

#	Year	Paper · Q	Marks · Words	Subject as printed	True owning topic	Foundations content genuinely required
P-1	2025	Prelims GS-I · Q92	Set A	BIMSTEC — four statements	advanced/10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings	Founding-member vs later-accession; declaration naming; sector leadership
P-2	2025	Prelims GS-I · Q97	Set A	BRICS — three statements	advanced/10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings	Full member vs partner country; chairship and venue; theme precision

 The rule this table enforces. ⚠️ Never present any of these as "a PYQ on strategic autonomy". In an interview, a test-series discussion or a self-made note, mislabelling an adjacent question as topic-owned produces a false sense of coverage and, worse, trains the habit of inventing provenance. The correct sentence is: "There is no direct PYQ on this topic; here is the nearest applied question and here is exactly which part of it requires the foundations."

PART II — SOLVED APPLICATION PYQs (MAINS)

M-1 · GS-II 2024, Question 9 · 10 marks · 150 words

✓ Exact question, verbatim from the official paper (typographical errors are in the printed paper and are reproduced):

"The West is fostering India as an alternative to reduce dependence on China's supply chain and as a strategically to counter China's political and economic dominance." Explain this statement with examples.

(Answer in 150 words.) 10

Ownership label: ⚠️ APPLICATION PYQ. Owned by advanced/03_India-China-Major-Powers-and-Resilient-Supply-Chains. Not owned by Topic 01.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Explain with examples — establish the mechanism and illustrate it. Not "critically examine": heavy counter-argument is not required, but a one-line qualification is expected at this level.
Subject	The West's strategy, not India's. The grammatical subject of the sentence is "The West".
Two limbs	(i) economic — reduce supply-chain dependence on China; (ii) strategic — counter China's political and economic dominance. Both must be answered.
Hidden trap	The verb "fostering" casts India as an object. A high answer notices this and re-centres India's agency without being combative.
Word discipline	150 words. Two limbs + examples + one qualification. No introduction longer than one line.

✓ Model answer (≈ 150 words)

India's growing weight in Western supply-chain and security calculations reflects two distinct Western interests.

Economic limb — de-risking. Concentration of manufacturing in one jurisdiction created a resilience problem for Western economies. India offers scale, a large domestic market and policy incentives for electronics, pharmaceuticals and semiconductors, making it the principal candidate for diversified sourcing. Instruments are trade and technology frameworks and investment facilitation, not treaty commitments.

Strategic limb — balancing. Western states seek a large Indo-Pacific partner with independent capability. Hence deepening defence-technology cooperation, exemplified by the ten-year US–India Major Defense Partnership framework signed on 31 October 2025, and participation in non-treaty minilaterals such as the Quad, which carries no collective-defence obligation.

△ The necessary qualification. Being fostered is not autonomy. India's engagement is reciprocal and interest-based, not derivative: as Sikri argues, India can become a major power "only on its own strength and political will, not because others want it to". Convergence is welcomed; co-option is not.

What an outstanding answer must contain

1. Separation of the two limbs — economic de-risking and strategic balancing — with a distinct instrument named under each.
2. At least one dated instrument with its correct status: the 31 October 2025 defence framework is ideal because it is dated, signed and not an alliance.
3. Correct characterisation of the Quad as a non-treaty coalition. Calling it an alliance in this answer is a factual error that a marker will notice.
4. The agency re-centring, in one clause, not a paragraph. This is what distinguishes a 6/10 from a 9/10.
5. No prediction about India "becoming the factory of the world" or "replacing China". Directional language only.
6. India's own interest heads named — growth and technology — so that the answer is not written entirely from the West's point of view.

Skeleton and timing (8–9 minutes)

0:00–0:45 Read; underline "The West is fostering" and the two limbs
 0:45–1:30 Outline: limb 1 / limb 2 / instrument each / qualification
 1:30–4:00 Limb 1 : de-risking + instrument
 4:00–6:30 Limb 2 : balancing + dated instrument + Quad status
 6:30–8:00 Qualification + close on autonomy
 8:00–8:30 Scan for status errors ("alliance", "delivered", "will")

Common mistakes

- ✗ Writing an India–US relations essay instead of answering about the West's strategy.
- ✗ Calling the Quad an alliance or an "Asian NATO".
- ✗ Listing production-linked incentive schemes at length — that is an Economy answer, and it consumes the word budget.
- ✗ Omitting the qualification entirely, producing an answer that reads as flattered rather than analytical.
- ✗ Predicting outcomes ("India will replace China by 2030").

M-2 · GS-II 2025, Question 19 · 15 marks · 250 words

✓ Exact question, verbatim from the official paper:

"Energy security constitutes the dominant kingpin of India's foreign policy, and is linked with India's overarching influence in Middle Eastern countries." How would you integrate energy security with India's foreign policy trajectories in the coming years?

(Answer in 250 words.)

Ownership label: △ APPLICATION PYQ. Owned by advanced/06_West-Asia-Energy-Security-and-Connectivity. Not owned by Topic 01. △ It is nonetheless the closest question in the entire 2018–2025 set, because its stem contains the phrase "India's foreign policy" and asks for

integration across trajectories — which is a request for the foundations chain in explicit form.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	"How would you integrate ..." — a prescriptive, forward-looking demand. The bulk of the answer must be the integration design, not a description of the Gulf.
Embedded claim	That energy security is the "dominant kingpin". Δ A strong answer qualifies this: energy is dominant among resource interests, but security and technology interests are not subordinate to it.
Second clause	"linked with India's overarching influence in Middle Eastern countries" — requires the leverage limb, not only the dependence limb.
Trajectories, plural	Requires more than one axis: supply diversification, transit/connectivity, diaspora, finance and the energy transition.
Word discipline	250 words. Roughly 60 words framing, 140 integration, 50 constraint and close.

✓ Model answer (≈250 words)

Energy sits at the intersection of three interest heads — resources, security and diaspora welfare — which is why it disproportionately shapes India's external choices. Δ It is dominant among resource interests rather than over all interests.

The Gulf's dual character. The relationship is simultaneously a source of vulnerability and of leverage: import dependence exposes India to price and chokepoint risk, while a diaspora Sikri estimates at about five million gives India, in his words, "vital interests in, and considerable influence over, this energy-rich region". Integration must exploit the second while insuring against the first.

Five trajectories.

1. Source diversification across politically incompatible suppliers. Correlation, not count, reduces risk. ✓ Russia's share of India's oil-import value reached an eleven-month high of nearly 38% in April 2026 — with a 425% jump in the premium charged — showing that diversification itself is volatile and priced.
2. Institutionalised political cover. The Second India–Arab Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 31 January 2026, and its Delhi Declaration, create a standing ministerial channel; Δ a declaration is political, not binding, and must be described as such.
3. Transit and connectivity, sequenced honestly — the IMEC MoU of 9 September 2023 is a framework of intent among eight signatories, not an operating corridor.
4. Diaspora and consular capacity treated as energy infrastructure, since welfare shocks transmit directly into supply politics.
5. The energy transition as an autonomy instrument, not merely a climate one: every domestically generated unit is a unit no third party can price.

Constraint and close. Chokepoint geography, third-party sanctions exposure and price volatility cap what diplomacy alone can deliver; the calibrated course is to diversify further, indigenise, and avoid exclusivity — preserving the freedom to choose the next supplier.

What an outstanding answer must contain

1. Qualification of the "kingpin" claim — accepting it uncritically forfeits the analytical mark; rejecting it outright misreads the directive.
2. The dual leverage–vulnerability reading of the Gulf, with the diaspora datum attached.
3. At least one dated quantitative anchor. The April 2026 share-and-premium pair is ideal because it demonstrates that diversification is not a costless solution.

4. Correct instrument statuses — Delhi Declaration as political; IMEC MoU as a framework of intent among eight signatories. Upgrading either is the most likely factual error in this answer.
5. The transition-as-autonomy argument, which almost no candidate makes and which directly serves the "trajectories" demand.
6. A constraint paragraph naming geography and sanctions exposure — not a generic "challenges remain".
7. No prediction of self-sufficiency by a stated year.

Skeleton and timing (12–14 minutes)

0:00-1:00 Read twice; note "how would YOU integrate" = prescriptive
 1:00-2:30 Outline five trajectories; pick the two dated anchors
 2:30-4:30 Framing : three interest heads + qualification of "kingpin"
 4:30-6:00 Dual character of the Gulf (vulnerability + leverage)
 6:00-10:30 Five trajectories, one crisp sentence each, statuses correct
 10:30-12:30 Constraint + calibrated close on autonomy
 12:30-13:30 Scan: any "will"? any upgraded instrument? any undated claim?

Common mistakes

- ✗ Writing a West Asia country survey (Saudi Arabia, UAE, Iran, Israel in turn) and never reaching "integration".
- ✗ Treating the Delhi Declaration or the IMEC MoU as binding or operational.
- ✗ Reciting import-dependence percentages without a date or a source class.
- ✗ Ignoring the diaspora entirely, which discards the leverage limb the stem explicitly asks for.
- ✗ Treating renewables purely as a climate item, missing the autonomy argument.

M-3 · GS-II 2025, Question 10 · 10 marks · 150 words

✓ Exact question, verbatim from the official paper:

"With the waning of globalization, post-Cold War world is becoming a site of sovereign nationalism." Elucidate.

(Answer in 150 words.)

Ownership label: APPLICATION PYQ. Owned by

advanced/11_Globalisation-Trade-Agreements-and-External-Policy-Effects. Not owned by Topic 01.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Elucidate — expand and make clear. It does not invite disagreement. A candidate who spends half the answer disputing the premise has misread the directive.
Two moving parts	(i) the waning of globalisation; (ii) the rise of sovereign nationalism. The answer must connect them causally, not merely assert both.
Scope	Systemic, not Indian. India appears as illustration, not as subject.
Word discipline	150 words: ~40 mechanism, ~70 manifestations with evidence, ~40 implication.

✓ Model answer (≈ 150 words)

The proposition describes a shift from rule-following to bargaining as the organising logic of the international system.

Mechanism. When multilateral rule-making weakens — through blocked dispute settlement, stalled institutional reform and fragmented standard-setting — states can no longer rely on rules to secure predictable outcomes. They substitute unilateral instruments: tariffs, export controls, industrial subsidies, data-localisation and extra-territorial sanctions. Each

substitution reasserts sovereign discretion over a domain previously governed by common rules.

Manifestations. Supply-chain de-risking rebuilds national industrial capacity at the cost of efficiency. Energy and technology are treated as security categories rather than traded goods. ✓ An additional duty imposed on specified Indian goods on account of purchases of third-country oil, effective 27 August 2025 and removed from 7 February 2026, illustrates the pattern precisely: an economic instrument used unilaterally for a strategic purpose, and then withdrawn through bilateral negotiation rather than adjudication.

Implication. △ In such an order, strategic autonomy ceases to be a doctrinal preference and becomes an operational necessity: where rules do not protect, only retained freedom of choice does.

What an outstanding answer must contain

1. A stated mechanism connecting the waning of globalisation to sovereign nationalism — most answers assert the two and connect neither.
2. The rule-following → bargaining formulation, which is compact and analytically precise.
3. At least one dated instance, and preferably one whose withdrawal is also dated, because that demonstrates the bargaining character of the order.
4. The implication clause, tying the systemic observation back to India's own doctrine — the move that makes this a GS-II answer rather than a general-studies essay.
5. No dispute with the premise. "Elucidate" is not "critically examine".
6. The sanctions-obligation distinction implicitly respected: another state's unilateral measure is not a legal obligation on India.

Skeleton and timing (8–9 minutes)

0:00-0:40 Note the directive: ELUCIDATE = expand, do not doubt
 0:40-1:20 Outline: mechanism / manifestations / implication
 1:20-3:30 Mechanism (rule-following → bargaining)
 3:30-6:30 Manifestations + the dated instance with BOTH dates
 6:30-8:00 Implication : autonomy as necessity, not preference
 8:00-8:30 Scan for accidental disagreement with the premise

Common mistakes

- ✗ Disputing the premise, which the directive forbids.
- ✗ Writing a history of globalisation from 1991 — the chronology-substitution gap.
- ✗ Naming instruments without dates, which reduces evidence to assertion.
- ✗ Describing another state's unilateral tariff as though it created a legal obligation on India.
- ✗ Ending without connecting the systemic claim to India's doctrine.

M-4 · GS-II 2020, Question 19 · 15 marks · 250 words

△ Wording note, stated honestly. The 2020 GS-II paper in books/more_previous_papers/Gen_St_P2.pdf carries a degraded OCR layer, and the printed English text of Q19 could not be recovered verbatim in this session. ✓ The read-only provenance ledger, which was compiled by reading the official paper, records the question as: "Quadrilateral Security Dialogue shifting from alliance to trade bloc — Discuss · 15 marks · 250 words." ? The exact printed sentence is therefore not reproduced; the theme, directive, marks and word limit are given as recorded. Do not quote a reconstructed stem as if verbatim.

Ownership label: △ APPLICATION PYQ. Owned by advanced/10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings. Not owned by Topic 01.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Discuss — balanced treatment plus a verdict.
Embedded premise	That the Quad was an alliance and is becoming a trade bloc. △ Both halves are contestable, and the first is simply inaccurate.
The high-risk move	Correcting the premise. It is worth doing only if done in one courteous clause and immediately followed by a substantive answer.
The real question	Functional evolution: is the Quad's agenda broadening from security into economic and technological cooperation, and what does that mean for India?
Word discipline	250 words: ~50 premise correction and definition, ~120 evolution with evidence, ~50 implication for India, ~30 verdict.

✓ Model answer (≈250 words)

Characterisation first. The Quadrilateral Security Dialogue has never been an alliance in the technical sense: it carries no mutual-defence obligation, no integrated command and no treaty. It is a non-treaty, issue-specific minilateral coalition — precisely the institutional form that suits a state pursuing strategic autonomy, because it permits deep cooperation without transferring decision rights.

The functional broadening is real. From an initial maritime and disaster-response focus, the agenda has extended into critical and emerging technologies, resilient supply chains, maritime domain awareness, infrastructure and health security. △ This is agenda-widening, not institutional transformation: a coalition acquires working groups, not obligations.

Why it is not a trade bloc either. A trade bloc requires preferential market access, common external arrangements or a rules framework binding its members. The Quad has none. Supply-chain resilience initiatives are coordination mechanisms; they do not confer tariff preferences.

Implication for India. Precisely this ambiguity is the attraction. India can pursue technology and supply-chain interests through the Quad while simultaneously chairing BRICS in 2026 and hosting its Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 14–15 May 2026 — an incompatibility only if the Quad were an alliance. △ The cost is that ambiguity invites doubt from partners on both sides, and that doubt is periodically priced.

Verdict. △ The premise is best restated rather than accepted: the Quad has shifted from a narrow security consultation to a broad-spectrum coalition, and has been neither an alliance nor a trade bloc at any point. That evolution suits India, at the cost of managing continuous suspicion.

What an outstanding answer must contain

1. The technical definition of an alliance — a mutual-defence obligation — stated in the first two lines, because everything else depends on it.
2. A courteous restatement of the premise, not a confrontation with it. "Best restated rather than accepted" is the register.
3. The reason the Quad is not a trade bloc either — most answers correct only the first half of the premise and accept the second.
4. The autonomy explanation of why the non-treaty form is chosen deliberately.
5. A dated simultaneity example: the BRICS chairship and the 14–15 May 2026 Foreign Ministers' Meeting demonstrate the compatibility claim empirically.
6. A named cost. An answer that presents ambiguity as costless is one-sided.
7. A verdict, because the directive is "Discuss".

Skeleton and timing (12–14 minutes)

0:00-1:30 Identify the false premise; decide to restate, not confront
 1:30-3:00 Define alliance; define trade bloc; place the Quad in neither
 3:00-7:00 Functional broadening with the agenda list
 7:00-9:30 Why not a trade bloc; why the form is chosen
 9:30-12:00 Implication for India + dated simultaneity + the cost
 12:00-13:30 Verdict; scan for the word "alliance" used loosely

Common mistakes

- ✗ Accepting the premise and writing about a "declining alliance".
- ✗ Correcting only the alliance half and conceding the trade-bloc half.
- ✗ Confrontational premise-correction that consumes 100 words.
- ✗ Listing Quad summits chronologically instead of analysing form.
- ✗ Presenting India's simultaneous engagements without naming the cost.

M-5 · GS-II 2019, Question 19 · 15 marks · 250 words

⚠ Wording note. The 2019 GS-II paper (QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-II.pdf) carries a heavily degraded OCR layer and Q19's printed English text could not be recovered verbatim in this session. ✓ The read-only provenance ledger records: "India's image as leader of the oppressed and marginalised nations — Elaborate · 15 marks · 250 words." ? Exact printed wording not reproduced.

Ownership label: ⚠ APPLICATION PYQ. Owned by advanced/08_Global-South-and-Development-Partnering. Not owned by Topic 01.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Elaborate — expand a stated proposition. Take the image as given; explain its sources, its instruments and its present form. Heavy scepticism is off-brief.
Key word	"Image" — the question is about reputation, an interest head in its own right, not about material outcomes.
Temporal span	The image has a historical source and a contemporary expression; both are needed.
Word discipline	250 words: ~60 sources, ~110 instruments across eras, ~50 present form, ~30 honest qualification.

✓ Model answer (≈250 words)

India's standing among post-colonial states rests on reputation, which functions as a distinct national-interest head: influence obtained through credibility rather than through capability.

Sources. The image was built before India possessed material weight. ✓ Sikri records that "from the very beginning, India's foreign policy concerned itself not only with India's narrow national interests, but also how it would impact other colonies in Asia and Africa", tracing the impulse to Gandhi's encounters with racism in South Africa. Its yield was disproportionate: on Sikri's account, moral clarity gave India "an influence in world affairs out of proportion to its real economic and political strength".

Instruments, by era. Convening: the Asian Relations Conference in New Delhi in March 1947, before independence; the Colombo conference of 1954; the Bandung Afro-Asian Conference of 1955, called by India with the other Colombo powers; the Belgrade non-aligned conference of 1961, where Nehru stood with Nasser and Tito. Advocacy: sustained opposition to apartheid and colonialism, and the AFRICA Fund launched at the Harare non-aligned summit of 1986. Delivery: development partnership, lines of credit and technical cooperation.

Present form. The vocabulary has migrated from "Third World" to Global South, and the instrument from movement-building to convening: India has hosted three Voice of Global South Summits — 12–13 January 2023, 17

November 2023 and 17 August 2024 — all virtually.

△ The honest qualification. Solidarity and interest are not separable here. Aggregating developing-country voice simultaneously advances India's own institutional-reform agenda — and Sikri concedes that the same moral register that won admirers also produced "moralistic posturing" that irritated others.

What an outstanding answer must contain

1. Reputation named as an interest head, which converts an "image" question from soft to analytical.
2. A pre-independence anchor — the March 1947 Asian Relations Conference is the strongest available, because it precedes sovereignty itself.
3. Instruments organised by era, not a chronological list. Convening → advocacy → delivery → convening again.
4. The three VOGSS editions with exact dates, and no invented fourth.
5. The inseparability point — that solidarity and institutional-voice interest coexist — stated as an analytical observation, not an accusation.
6. Sikri's two-sided passage, which supplies both the achievement and its cost from one source.
7. No claim about delivered development outcomes without a dated instrument.

Skeleton and timing (12–14 minutes)

0:00-1:00 Directive is ELABORATE : expand, do not attack
 1:00-2:30 Outline: sources / instruments by era / present form / caveat
 2:30-5:00 Sources with the Sikri quotations
 5:00-9:30 Instruments : convening -> advocacy -> delivery
 9:30-11:30 Present form : Global South, three VOGSS editions, dated
 11:30-13:00 Honest qualification; close
 13:00-13:30 Scan: any invented summit? any undated claim?

Common mistakes

- ✗ Converting an "elaborate" into a critique of India's Global South record.
- ✗ Inventing a fourth Voice of Global South Summit.
- ✗ Confusing Bandung (1955) with the first non-aligned summit (Belgrade, 1961).
- ✗ Claiming delivered development outcomes without a dated instrument.
- ✗ Treating "image" as though it were merely rhetorical, and so failing to name reputation as an interest.

M-6 · GS-II 2023, Question 19 · 15 marks · 250 words

△ Wording note. The 2023 GS-II paper's OCR layer drops function words. ✓ The recovered printed English fragment reads: "The expansion strengthening NATO and a stronger US-Europe strategic partnership works well India.' What your opinion about this statement ? Give reasons examples support your answer." ✓ The provenance ledger records the theme as "Expansion of NATO and a stronger US–Europe partnership for India", directive "What is your opinion, with reasons", 15 marks · 250 words. ? The dropped function words are not reconstructed as if verbatim.

Ownership label: △ APPLICATION PYQ. Owned by advanced/10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings. Not owned by Topic 01.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	"What is your opinion ... give reasons and examples" — an opinion question, which demands a stated position, defended. Fence-sitting is penalised here specifically.
Subject	A treaty alliance (NATO) and a strategic partnership (US–Europe). The distinction between the two is itself examinable.

Element	Reading
Trap	The stem invites a yes/no. The best answer gives a conditional opinion — "works well for India in respects X and Y; works against India in respect Z" — which is a position, not evasion.
Word discipline	250 words: ~40 conceptual framing, ~90 the "works well" case, ~70 the counter-case, ~50 the conditional verdict.

✓ Model answer (~250 words)

Framing. NATO is a treaty alliance with a collective-defence obligation; the US–Europe strategic partnership is a broader alignment of policy. India is party to neither, and its interest is therefore in the effects of both, not in membership of either.

The case that it works well for India. A cohesive transatlantic bloc stabilises the European theatre, sustains a large market and technology base with which India increasingly cooperates on trade, semiconductors and green technology, and disperses global power away from a single dominant pole — which serves India's preference for multipolarity. It also reduces the likelihood that Europe becomes a security dependency of a rival power.

The case against. △ Three costs. First, a consolidated Western bloc raises the pressure on India to align, converting issue-based freedom into a loyalty test. Second, the resulting confrontation deepens Russia's dependence on China, which is directly adverse to Indian interests. Third, alliance solidarity makes it easier for members to impose extra-territorial economic measures on non-members — as the additional duty on specified Indian goods, effective 27 August 2025 and removed from 7 February 2026, illustrates.

Conditional verdict. △ Transatlantic cohesion works well for India as a source of capability, market access and multipolar balance, and works against India as a source of alignment pressure and as an accelerant of Russia–China convergence. India's response should be neither endorsement nor objection but diversification: deepen European economic and technology ties bilaterally while refusing the framing that requires a choice.

What an outstanding answer must contain

1. The alliance-versus-partnership distinction in the opening lines — it is the conceptual key to the whole question.
2. A genuine position. "Works well in respects X and Y, works against in respect Z" is a position; "there are pros and cons" is not.
3. The Russia–China convergence argument, which is the single most India-specific cost and which weak answers omit entirely.
4. A dated instance of extra-territorial economic pressure, with both its imposition and removal dates.
5. Multipolarity named as an Indian preference, connecting the systemic observation to Indian doctrine.
6. A response recommendation that is directional, not a prediction and not a demand that NATO change.
7. No claim of Indian membership, partnership status or obligation in relation to NATO.

Skeleton and timing (12–14 minutes)

0:00-1:00 Note: opinion question. Decide the CONDITIONAL verdict first.
 1:00-2:00 Outline: framing / for / against / conditional verdict
 2:00-3:30 Alliance vs partnership; India is party to neither
 3:30-7:00 The "works well" case: stability, market, technology, multipolarity
 7:00-10:30 The counter-case: alignment pressure, Russia-China, extra-territoriality
 10:30-12:30 Conditional verdict + directional response
 12:30-13:30 Scan: is there an actual position? any status error?

Common mistakes

- ✗ Writing a NATO history and enlargement chronology.
- ✗ Failing to state a position, which this directive specifically punishes.
- ✗ Omitting the Russia–China convergence cost.
- ✗ Implying India has some formal relationship with NATO.

- ✕ Recommending that NATO or the US change its policy, rather than recommending India's response.

M-7 · GS-II 2021, Question 10 · 10 marks · 150 words

△ Wording note. ✓ The recovered printed English fragment from the official 2021 paper reads: "The is facing existential threat form China, that much more challenging than erstwhile Soviet Union.' Explain." ✓ The provenance ledger records the theme as "The USA facing an existential challenge from China", directive Explain, 10 marks · 150 words. ? Dropped words are not reconstructed as verbatim.

Ownership label: △ APPLICATION PYQ. Owned by advanced/03_India-China-Major-Powers-and-Resilient-Supply-Chains. Not owned by Topic 01.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Explain — establish why the challenge is of a different character from the Soviet one. Mechanism, then illustration.
The comparative	"More challenging than the erstwhile Soviet Union" is the analytical core. An answer that describes US–China rivalry without the comparison has answered a different question.
India's place	Not the subject — but a closing implication clause is expected in GS-II.
Word discipline	150 words: ~30 the claim, ~85 the three differences, ~35 implication for India.

✓ Model answer (≈ 150 words)

The claim rests on a difference of kind, not of degree.

First, economic interdependence. The Soviet Union was a rival outside the American economic system; China is embedded within it, as a manufacturing base, creditor and market. Competition therefore cannot be pursued by containment without self-injury.

Second, technological parity. Soviet competition was concentrated in military and space domains. Chinese competition extends into commercial general-purpose technologies — telecommunications, semiconductors, artificial intelligence, clean energy — where standards and supply chains, not warheads, determine advantage.

Third, institutional presence. The Soviet Union largely built parallel institutions; China operates inside existing ones while also creating new ones, contesting rules from within.

△ Implication for India. In such a contest, India's posture is best described as hedging rather than balancing or bandwagoning: engaging both poles on distinct issues while building independent capability. Bandwagoning would forfeit autonomy; formal balancing would import a confrontation India has not chosen.

What an outstanding answer must contain

1. The "difference of kind" formulation stated at the outset.
2. Three distinct axes — interdependence, technology, institutions — rather than a single point elaborated.
3. Correct use of the triad in the implication clause. Using "balancing" loosely here is the commonest error.
4. A reason why bandwagoning is rejected, not merely an assertion that India hedges.
5. Restraint. 150 words does not permit a survey of US–China flashpoints; naming three and analysing none is worse than analysing three axes.
6. No prediction about who prevails.

Skeleton and timing (8–9 minutes)

0:00-0:40 Identify the comparative as the core demand
 0:40-1:20 Outline three axes + implication
 1:20-6:30 Three axes, one tight paragraph each
 6:30-8:00 Implication : hedging, with the reason bandwagoning fails
 8:00-8:30 Scan: is the comparison actually made three times?

Common mistakes

- ✗ Describing US–China tensions without ever comparing them to the Soviet case.
- ✗ Using "balancing" as a synonym for "hedging".
- ✗ Turning the answer into an India–China border answer.
- ✗ Predicting the outcome of the rivalry.
- ✗ Listing flashpoints (Taiwan, South China Sea, trade) as a substitute for analysis.

M-8 · GS-II 2025, Question 20 · 15 marks · 250 words

✓ Exact question, verbatim from the official paper:

"The reform process in the United Nations remains unresolved, because of the delicate imbalance of East and West and entanglement of the USA vs. Russo-Chinese alliance." Examine and critically evaluate the East-West policy confrontations in this regard.

(Answer in 250 words.)

Ownership label: APPLICATION PYQ. Owned by advanced/12_UN-and-International-Institutions-Global-Governance. Not owned by Topic 01.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	"Examine and critically evaluate" — a double directive: test the components of the stated explanation, then judge it.
The stem's causal claim	That reform is blocked because of East–West imbalance and US-versus-Russo-Chinese entanglement. This is a partial explanation, and "critically evaluate" invites the candidate to say so.
The word "alliance"	The stem describes a "Russo-Chinese alliance". A precise candidate notes, in a clause, that this is a strategic alignment rather than a treaty alliance — without derailing the answer.
What is missing from the stem	Intra-aspirant rivalry (the Uniting for Consensus grouping), African common-position divergence, veto-holder self-interest generally — including among Western permanent members.
Word discipline	250 words: ~50 the stem's claim examined, ~90 the additional blockages, ~60 evaluation, ~50 India's interest and way forward.

✓ Model answer (≈250 words)

Examining the stated explanation. Great-power confrontation is a genuine blockage: Security Council reform requires Charter amendment, which needs ratification by two-thirds of members including all five permanent members, so any single veto-holder's reluctance is decisive. A precision point: Russia–China is a strategic alignment, not a treaty alliance, and describing it as the latter overstates its cohesion.

But the explanation is incomplete. Three further blockages operate independently of East–West rivalry.

1. Intra-aspirant rivalry. Regional competitors of the aspirant states have organised specifically to prevent new permanent seats — a South–South obstruction that no East–West framing captures.
2. Divergence over the terms. Positions differ on whether new permanent members should hold the veto, and on regional representation formulas, so aspirants are not a single bloc.

3. Universal veto-holder self-interest. Reluctance to dilute the veto is not confined to one side of the East–West line; it is a structural feature of holding one.

Evaluation.  The stem identifies the most visible blockage but mistakes a sufficient condition for the only one. Even a full East–West rapprochement would leave the second and third blockages intact.

India's interest and course. India's stake is rule-shaping — voice in the body that authorises the use of force and sets the normative agenda. Given structural blockage, the calibrated course is to build weight in the venues that are actually movable: chairships and presidencies, Global South convening, and coalitions such as the G4, while continuing to press the principal reform demand.

What an outstanding answer must contain

1. The Charter-amendment mechanism stated precisely — two-thirds plus all five permanent members — because it converts the answer from opinion to law.
2. The alignment-versus-alliance precision point, in one clause.
3. At least two blockages absent from the stem. This is what "critically evaluate" demands and what most answers omit.
4. An explicit verdict on the stem's completeness — "identifies the most visible blockage but mistakes it for the only one".
5. India's interest named as rule-shaping, not vaguely as "a permanent seat".
6. A movable-venue recommendation, which is directional and realistic, rather than a demand that reform occur.
7. No prediction of a reform timeline.

Skeleton and timing (12–14 minutes)

0:00-1:00 Note double directive; note "alliance" imprecision
 1:00-2:30 Outline: examine / three additional blockages / verdict / India
 2:30-5:00 Examine the stem : Charter amendment mechanism + precision point
 5:00-9:00 Three additional blockages
 9:00-11:00 Verdict on completeness
 11:00-13:00 India's interest + movable venues
 13:00-13:30 Scan: is there a verdict? is "alliance" handled?

Common mistakes

- ✗ Reciting the history of UNSC reform proposals instead of analysing blockages.
- ✗ Accepting the stem's explanation as complete, which forfeits the "critically evaluate" mark.
- ✗ Treating "Russo-Chinese alliance" as a treaty alliance.
- ✗ Writing India's case for a permanent seat as an advocacy piece.
- ✗ Predicting reform by a date, or asserting that reform is impossible.

PART III — SOLVED APPLICATION PYQs (PRELIMS)

 Inclusion rule applied. Only Prelims questions whose official key could be verified from a locally held official UPSC answer-key PDF with extractable text are included. ? The 2026 provisional key is image-only in the local copy, so 2026 questions — including two genuinely relevant ones on unratified conventions and on visit outcomes — are omitted rather than answered from inference.

P-1 · Prelims GS-I 2025, Question 92 (Set A)

✓ Exact question, verbatim from the official paper:

Consider the following statements in respect of BIMSTEC :

I. It is a regional organization consisting of seven member States till January 2025.

II. It came into existence with the signing of the Dhaka Declaration, 1999.

III. Bangladesh, India, Lanka, Thailand and Nepal are founding member States of BIMSTEC.

IV. In BIMSTEC, the subsector of 'tourism' is being led by India.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) I and II (b) II and III (c) I and IV (d) I only

✓ Official key: (d) — UPSC provisional answer key, CS(P) 2025, Series A, Q92.

Ownership label:  APPLICATION PYQ. Owned by advanced/10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings.

Option-by-option explanation

Statement	Verdict	Why
I. Seven member States till January 2025	✓ Correct	BIMSTEC's membership stood at seven. This is the only statement the official key admits.
II. Came into existence with the Dhaka Declaration, 1999	✗ Incorrect	The founding instrument is the Bangkok Declaration of 1997. The statement substitutes both the city and the year — a double substitution, which is UPSC's standard method for a confidently wrong statement.
III. Bangladesh, India, Sri Lanka, Thailand and Nepal are founding members	✗ Incorrect	Nepal was not a founding member; it acceded later. The statement is constructed so that four of five names are right, which is what makes it dangerous.
IV. The 'tourism' subsector is led by India	✗ Incorrect per the official key	Following BIMSTEC's sectoral reorganisation, India's lead responsibility is in the security pillar.  Under the older fourteen-sector structure India had led several sectors, which is exactly the residual memory the distractor targets.

✓ **Answer: (d) — I only**

Topic relevance and trap logic

 Why this belongs in a foundations workbook. Three of the four statements test status and provenance precision, which is Subtopic 6's entire subject matter: the founding instrument (which declaration, which city, which year), founding versus acceding membership, and institutional role allocation after a reorganisation.

 *Trap logic. UPSC's four-statement format with an "only one is correct" key is designed to punish partial recall. The defence is not to know more BIMSTEC facts; it is to notice that statements II, III and IV each make a specific, checkable, falsifiable assertion — a named declaration, a named founding set, a named lead country — while statement I makes a bland, verifiable one. Bland statements are usually true; specific-and-embellished statements are where the error is planted.*

P-2 · Prelims GS-I 2025, Question 97 (Set A)

✓ Exact question, verbatim from the official paper:

Consider the following statements with regard to BRICS :

I. 16th BRICS Summit was held under the Chairship of Russia in Kazan.

II. Indonesia has become a full member of BRICS.

III. The theme of the 16th BRICS Summit was Strengthening Multiculturalism for Just Global Development and Security.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) I and II (b) II and III (c) I and III (d) I only

✓ Official key: (a) — UPSC provisional answer key, CS(P) 2025, Series A, Q97.

Ownership label: Δ APPLICATION PYQ. Owned by advanced/10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings.

Option-by-option explanation

Statement	Verdict	Why
I. 16th BRICS Summit under Russia's chairship, at Kazan	✓ Correct	The Kazan summit is also the occasion on which the partner-country category was created, on 24 October 2024 — a fact this workbook uses repeatedly.
II. Indonesia has become a full member	✓ Correct per the official key	Δ This is the statement that makes the question valuable: it turns on the distinction between full membership and partner-country status, and it is time-sensitive — the status changed between the Kazan summit and the examination date.
III. Theme: "Strengthening Multiculturalism for Just Global Development and Security"	✗ Incorrect	The actual theme used the word Multilateralism. The distractor substitutes a single similar-looking word.

✓ **Answer: (a) — I and II**

Topic relevance and trap logic

Δ Why this belongs in a foundations workbook. Statement II is the membership–participation gap in examination form — precisely the gap 00_Master-Framework.md Section 7 names. A candidate who has internalised that BRICS has members, partner countries and guests, and that these confer different rights, approaches statement II by asking "which category?" rather than "have I heard of Indonesia in BRICS?".

$\hookrightarrow$ Trap logic — the single-word substitution. "Multiculturalism" for "Multilateralism" is a reading trap, not a knowledge trap. It is defeated by a mechanical habit: when a statement quotes a title, theme or name, read it word by word rather than by shape. In the same paper, statement III of a different question and statement II of Q92 use the same technique with a city and a year.

$\hookrightarrow$ Trap logic — the time-sensitive status. Membership statuses change. The defence is to attach a date to every status fact: "partner category created at Kazan, 24 October 2024" is durable; "Indonesia is a partner" is not.

PART IV — 32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQs

Δ These are original questions written for this workbook. They are not PYQs and must never be represented as such. They span static doctrine and current application across all ten subtopics of the companion learning session.

$\hookrightarrow$ Answer-key rotation is strict: $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C \rightarrow D$, repeated exactly eight times. Q1 = A, Q2 = B, Q3 = C, Q4 = D, Q5 = A ... Q32 = D. Every question has four plausible options, a detailed explanation and an explicit statement of the trap logic.

Q1. Which one of the following best describes the relationship between a budget allocation to a partner country and a foreign-policy outcome?

(a) The allocation is an input; the outcome requires separate evidence of implementation, with its own date

- (b) The allocation is itself the outcome, since appropriation and delivery are simultaneous in development partnership
- (c) The allocation is a legally binding obligation to the recipient state under international law
- (d) The allocation is a grant that transfers ownership of funds to the recipient on the date of the Budget

✓ Answer: (a). An appropriation authorises spending; it does not evidence delivery. In the Union Budget 2026-27, ₹4,548 crore was earmarked for immediate neighbours out of a Ministry of External Affairs allocation of ₹22,118 crore — a figure that must be described as allocated, never as invested, spent or delivered.

✗ (b) collapses the announcement–delivery gap. ✗ (c) confuses a domestic appropriation with an international obligation — an appropriation creates no right in the recipient state. ✗ (d) confuses appropriation with disbursement and also assumes all such allocations are grants, when the same partnership may involve lines of credit, project-tied assistance and grants in different proportions.

🔗 Trap logic. The examinable habit is to treat money named in a Budget as the strongest possible evidence. It is in fact evidence of intent at scale — better than an MoU, weaker than a commissioned project.

Q2. With reference to Article 51 of the Constitution of India, consider the following statements:

- I. It directs the State to endeavour to foster respect for international law and treaty obligations.
- II. It expressly requires India to remain non-aligned in its external relations.
- III. It is a Directive Principle of State Policy and is non-justiciable.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) I and II only
- (b) I and III only
- (c) II and III only
- (d) I, II and III

✓ Answer: (b). ✓ I reproduces Article 51(c). ✓ III correctly places Article 51 in Part IV as a non-justiciable Directive Principle. ✗ II is false and is the central trap of this topic's constitutional limb: Article 51 speaks of international peace and security, just and honourable relations, respect for international law and treaty obligations, and settlement of disputes by arbitration. It nowhere mentions alignment, blocs or alliances. Non-alignment was a policy choice; Article 51 is a constitutional directive.

🔗 Trap logic. Because Article 51 and non-alignment are always taught in the same breath, candidates infer a legal link that does not exist. The corrective test is mechanical: can you quote a clause of Article 51 that mentions alignment? If not, the statement is false.

Q3. The five principles of Panchsheel include which of the following?

- I. Mutual respect for each other's territorial integrity and sovereignty
- II. Mutual non-aggression
- III. Collective self-defence against external aggression
- IV. Equality and mutual benefit

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) I, II and III only
- (b) II, III and IV only
- (c) I, II and IV only
- (d) I, III and IV only

✓ Answer: (c). The five principles are: mutual respect for territorial integrity and sovereignty; mutual non-aggression; mutual non-interference in internal affairs; equality and mutual benefit; and peaceful coexistence. ✗ III, "collective self-defence", is not among them — and it is the exact opposite of the doctrine's spirit, since collective self-defence is the organising principle of a military alliance.

🔗 Trap logic. The distractor is built by inserting an alliance concept into a coexistence framework. A candidate who has understood that Panchsheel and non-alignment both refuse bloc logic rejects III instantly, without needing to recall the list.

Q4. The five principles of peaceful coexistence were jointly enunciated in the preamble of which of the following?

- (a) The Final Communiqué of the Asian–African Conference held at Bandung
- (b) The declaration adopted at the first conference of non-aligned states at Belgrade
- (c) The Shanghai Communiqué signed by the United States and China
- (d) The Agreement on Trade and Intercourse between the Tibet Region of China and India

✓ Answer: (d). Panchsheel was set out in the preamble of the India–China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse between the Tibet Region of China and India, signed on 29 April 1954.

✗ (a) Bandung was held in 1955 — a year later — and echoed the principles rather than originating them. ✗ (b) Belgrade, 1961, was the first non-aligned conference, at which Nehru stood with Nasser and Tito. ✗ (c) The February 1972 Shanghai Communiqué did declare US–China relations to be based on the Five Principles — a striking later echo, and a superb distractor precisely because it is true as a statement about the communiqué while false as an answer to "where were they jointly enunciated".

🔗 Trap logic. Three of the four options are real documents that genuinely mention or echo the principles. The question is not "which document mentions Panchsheel" but "which one enunciated it". Reading the operative verb in a stem is the defence.

Q5. Nehru's formulation of non-alignment comprised which of the following elements?

- I. No military alliances with countries of either bloc
- II. An independent approach to foreign policy
- III. Friendly relations with all countries
- IV. Abstention from voting on all contentious matters in international forums

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) I, II and III only
- (b) I and IV only
- (c) II, III and IV only
- (d) I, II, III and IV

✓ Answer: (a). The formulation had three elements — no military alliance with either bloc; an independent approach; friendly relations with all countries — of which only the first is negative.

✗ IV is the passivity misreading in disguise. India took positions constantly: on Korea, on Suez, on decolonisation, on apartheid — Bipan Chandra records India as the first country to apply sanctions against apartheid South Africa by breaking off trade and diplomatic links.

🔗 Trap logic. The distractor sounds like a consequence of the first three. It is in fact their contradiction: a state that abstains on everything has no independent approach to express.

Q6. Which one of the following statements is correct regarding the distinction between non-alignment as a policy and the Non-Aligned Movement as an institution?

- (a) The policy ceased in 1991 while the Movement continues to determine India's foreign policy
- (b) The policy was a decision rule about refusing camp membership and judging issues on merit, whereas the Movement is an institution whose contemporary salience has narrowed
- (c) The policy applied only to security questions while the Movement applied only to economic questions
- (d) Both are legally binding on India by virtue of treaty commitments

✓ Answer: (b). Sikri states the distinction explicitly: non-alignment as a policy option, "as distinct from the Non-Aligned Movement, was essentially about resisting pressures to join rival camps during the Cold War and about examining foreign policy options on merit. In short, it was about having an independent foreign policy."

✗ (a) inverts the survival: the principle survived, relabelled; the Movement's salience narrowed. ✗ (c) invents a subject-matter division that no source supports. ✗ (d) is a category error — a foreign-policy posture and a movement's membership are not treaty obligations.

🔗 Trap logic. The question "is non-alignment still relevant?" is unanswerable until it is split into two questions. Candidates who cannot split it produce answers that are simultaneously true and false.

Q7. Non-alignment has been characterised as "not a blueprint for policy ... an approach, a framework, a method, not a straitjacket but a lodestar". Which of the following are cited as evidence supporting this characterisation?

- I. The close relationship that developed with the USSR from 1954 onwards
- II. India's decision to join the Commonwealth
- III. India's ability to obtain capital from countries on both sides of the Cold War divide

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) I and II only
- (b) II and III only
- (c) I, II and III
- (d) I only

✓ Answer: (c). All three appear in the same passage of India After Independence: non-alignment "did not come in the way of the close relationship that developed with the USSR from 1954 onwards. Nor did it come in the way of India joining the Commonwealth", and it "enabled her to develop economic ties with countries on both sides of the divide as and when she needed. She needed and got capital."

🔗 Trap logic. Each item, taken alone, looks like an exception to non-alignment and is often taught apologetically. Taken together they establish that flexibility was the design. A candidate who knows only one of the three tends to select a two-item option out of caution — which is exactly the hesitation the question is testing.

Q8. Consider the following events in India's diplomatic history:

- I. The Asian Relations Conference in New Delhi
- II. The Afro-Asian Conference at Bandung
- III. The first conference of non-aligned states at Belgrade
- IV. The signing of the agreement whose preamble set out Panchsheel

Which one of the following is the correct chronological sequence?

- (a) II – I – IV – III
- (b) I – III – IV – II

(c) IV – I – II – III

(d) I – IV – II – III

✓ Answer: (d). The Asian Relations Conference was held in New Delhi in March 1947, before independence; the Panchsheel agreement was signed on 29 April 1954; the Bandung Afro-Asian Conference was held in 1955, called by India with the other Colombo powers; and the first non-aligned conference was at Belgrade in 1961, where Nehru stood with Nasser and Tito.

🔗 Trap logic. The one fact most candidates get wrong is that the Asian Relations Conference preceded independence. Every incorrect option here depends on that error, on placing Belgrade before Bandung, or on placing Panchsheel after Bandung. Two anchors — "1947, before independence" and "Bandung 1955 was a precursor to Belgrade 1961" — resolve the whole sequence.

Q9. Strategic autonomy, as the term is used in Indian foreign-policy analysis, is best defined as

(a) the retained capacity to decide each external issue by India's own interest calculus, exercised through rather than against deep partnerships

(b) the practice of maintaining relationships of equal depth with all major powers

(c) abstention from binding international agreements in order to preserve freedom of action

(d) the pursuit of self-sufficiency in defence and energy so that external partnerships become unnecessary

✓ Answer: (a). Autonomy is a capacity, not a behaviour pattern. It is compatible with — indeed exercised through — deep, simultaneous and deliberately unequal partnerships. What defeats it is not depth but exclusivity.

✗ (b) is equidistance. ✗ (c) is isolation, and is refuted by the very large number of binding agreements India is party to. ✗ (d) confuses an instrument of autonomy (indigenisation) with autonomy itself, and overstates it into autarky.

🔗 Trap logic. Option (d) is the most sophisticated distractor because indigenisation genuinely is the only permanent mitigation of the autonomy–dependence trade-off. But a mitigation is not a definition, and self-sufficiency sufficient to make partnerships "unnecessary" is a different and unattainable claim.

Q10. Consider the following statements:

I. Strategic autonomy requires India to maintain equal distance from competing major powers.

II. Strategic autonomy is compatible with deepening a particular bilateral relationship, provided that relationship does not become exclusive.

III. Strategic autonomy is a post-1991 invention with no continuity with non-alignment.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) I and III only

(b) II only

(c) I and II only

(d) I, II and III

✓ Answer: (b). ✓ II states the doctrine correctly: depth is permitted, exclusivity is not.

✗ I is the equidistance error — India is deep with several partners unequally and simultaneously. ✗ III is the discontinuity error: strategic autonomy expresses the same principle that Sikri identifies at the heart of non-alignment — "in short, it was about having an independent foreign policy" — with only the label and the external context changed.

🔗 Trap logic. Statements I and III are the two commonest classroom formulations of strategic autonomy, which is precisely why they are used as distractors. When two statements in a three-statement question are popular, expect them to be the wrong ones.

Q11. Which of the following are recognised mitigations of the autonomy–dependence trade-off?

- I. Diversifying suppliers across politically incompatible blocs rather than merely increasing their number
- II. Building indigenous capability
- III. Writing reciprocity and technology-sharing conditions into the agreement itself
- IV. Avoiding deep bilateral partnerships altogether

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) I and IV only
- (b) II and IV only
- (c) I, II and III only
- (d) I, II, III and IV

✓ Answer: (c). ✓ I captures the key insight that correlation, not count, reduces risk: ten suppliers who all follow the same political lead are one supplier. ✓ II is the only permanent mitigation; every other buys time. ✓ III converts a hope into a clause.

✗ IV is the over-correction: avoidance forfeits precisely the technology, capital and market access that autonomy exists to secure, and would amount to isolation.

🔗 Trap logic. In critical-analysis questions the most attractive wrong option is the one that sounds most cautious. Caution that destroys the objective is not caution; it is a different policy.

Q12. A senior Indian practitioner has warned that it is "highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the US" in the absence of reciprocal technology-sharing. The core of this warning is that

- (a) India should reduce defence cooperation with all external partners
- (b) dependence on Russian equipment is inherently more dangerous than dependence on American equipment
- (c) technology-sharing is desirable but not material to strategic autonomy
- (d) simultaneous structural entanglement with two mutually hostile systems converts a hedge into a vulnerability

✓ Answer: (d). The warning is not about either supplier considered separately; it is about the combination. A state deeply reliant on one system while integrating its planning into a rival system holds two dependencies that can be played against each other — which is the precise mechanism by which a hedge inverts into an exposure.

✗ (a) is isolationism, which the source nowhere recommends. ✗ (b) misreads a structural argument as a preference between suppliers. ✗ (c) inverts the warning's conditional — the absence of reciprocal technology-sharing is exactly what makes the enmeshment unwise.

🔗 Trap logic. Long quotations invite candidates to seize on the most emotive noun ("Russian", "US") and miss the logical operator. Here the operative words are "enmesh" and "without reciprocal technology-sharing".

Q13. The concept of "multi-alignment" was articulated with reference to India belonging simultaneously to which of the following pairs?

- I. The United Nations and the G20
- II. The Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies
- III. The G77 and IOR-ARC
- IV. NATO and the Warsaw Pact

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) I, II and III only
- (b) II, III and IV only
- (c) I and IV only
- (d) I, II, III and IV

✓ Answer: (a). The enumeration in *Pax Indica* pairs the United Nations with the G20; the Non-Aligned Movement with the Community of Democracies; the G77 with IOR-ARC; SAARC with the Commonwealth; RIC with BRICS; and IBSA with BASIC — concluding, "India is the one country that is a member of them all."

✗ IV is impossible on two counts: India was never a member of either, and the Warsaw Pact was dissolved in 1991. Its inclusion tests whether the candidate reads multi-alignment as "membership of opposed non-treaty platforms" or, wrongly, as "membership of opposed military alliances".

🔗 Trap logic. The whole doctrine is misread if the pairs are taken to be alliances. Option (d) is the trap for candidates who remember the structure (pairs of opposites) without the content (non-treaty platforms).

Q14. Which of the following characterisations of multi-alignment were offered by the author who coined the term?

- I. That it is, at one level, an amoral strategy
- II. That it is a promiscuous strategy, exempting no country from its embrace
- III. That it is a strategy of making and running shifting coalitions of interests
- IV. That it renders bilateral diplomacy obsolete

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) I and IV only
- (b) I, II and III only
- (c) II and IV only
- (d) I, II, III and IV

✓ Answer: (b). All three of I, II and III are the author's own words in *Pax Indica*, Chapter 11 — "at one level an amoral strategy"; "also a promiscuous strategy, since it exempts no country from its embrace"; "a strategy of making and running shifting coalitions of interests".

✗ IV is false: multi-alignment operates at every level, and the same author's argument is that bilateral relationships remain central, with the doctrine describing how they are combined.

🔗 Trap logic. Candidates instinctively reject I and II because they sound like criticisms — and they are criticisms, offered by the proponent himself. Quoting a proponent's own concession is the strongest available form of balance in a Mains answer, and this question is designed to make that memorable.

Q15. Match the strategic posture with its definition:

Posture	Definition
A. Balancing	1. Aligning with the stronger power in order to share its gains
B. Bandwagoning	2. Engaging more than one power on different issues while avoiding exclusive commitment to any
C. Hedging	3. Aligning against a rising or threatening power in order to check it

Select the correct code:

- (a) A-1, B-2, C-3
- (b) A-2, B-3, C-1

(c) A-3, B-1, C-2

(d) A-3, B-2, C-1

✓ Answer: (c). Balancing aligns against; bandwagoning aligns with the stronger power; hedging engages both on different issues without exclusive commitment. India's posture toward the US–China dynamic is best described as hedging, evidenced by the ten-year US–India Major Defense Partnership framework signed on 31 October 2025 and the 23rd India–Russia Annual Summit held on 4–5 December 2025.

🔗 Trap logic. Option (d) swaps only bandwagoning and hedging, which is the commonest real-world confusion — because both involve engaging rather than opposing. The distinguishing test is exclusivity: the bandwagoner accepts one patron's priorities; the hedger accepts none.

Q16. In assessing India's external engagements as a "portfolio", which of the following observations is most accurate?

(a) Increasing the number of partners is by itself sufficient to reduce strategic risk

(b) The portfolio analogy holds completely, since partners behave like financial assets

(c) The analogy fails entirely and should not be used in analysis

(d) Correlation between partners matters more than their number, and the analogy breaks down because partners, unlike assets, react to one another

✓ Answer: (d). Ten partners who all follow the same political lead constitute one partner for risk purposes — which is why India's engagement with rival poles, rather than with many states, is the load-bearing feature. The analogy nevertheless breaks on three points: partners resent each other in a way assets do not; some dependencies (defence platforms built over decades) are illiquid; and there is no benchmark against which the portfolio's performance can be measured.

✗ (a) is the count-not-correlation error. ✗ (b) ignores all three breaking points. ✗ (c) over-corrects: the analogy genuinely illuminates diversification and rebalancing.

🔗 Trap logic. Both (a) and (c) are single-move answers — one accepts the analogy uncritically, the other rejects it uncritically. The examinable skill is knowing where a useful analogy stops being useful.

Q17. Arrange the following instruments in ascending order of binding character (least binding first):

I. Memorandum of Understanding

II. Charter in force

III. Dialogue mechanism

IV. Joint declaration

(a) III – I – IV – II

(b) I – III – II – IV

(c) IV – III – I – II

(d) II – IV – I – III

✓ Answer: (a). A dialogue mechanism produces no binding output by itself; an MoU is a statement of intent and is not self-executing; a joint declaration is a political and normative commitment; a charter in force binds member states.

🔗 Trap logic. Ordering questions defeat candidates who have memorised definitions individually without ever placing them on a single scale. Drawing the six-rung ladder once from memory — dialogue, MoU, declaration, signed-not-in-force, charter in force, treaty in force — immunises against the entire family.

Q18. With reference to the BBNJ Agreement, consider the following statements:

I. It entered into force in January 2026.

II. India signed the Agreement in September 2024.

III. Following entry into force, the Agreement's substantive obligations apply to all signatory States, whether or not they have deposited instruments of ratification.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) I and III only
- (b) I and II only
- (c) II and III only
- (d) I, II and III

✓ Answer: (b). ✓ I — the Agreement on Marine Biological Diversity of Areas Beyond National Jurisdiction entered into force on 17 January 2026, after the sixty-ratification threshold was crossed. ✓ II — India signed on 25 September 2024. ✗ III is the legal-status gap in its purest form: a multilateral treaty in force is binding only on States that have deposited ratification or accession. India's instrument had not been deposited, which is precisely why a domestic BBNJ Bill was placed in public consultation in 2026 — a State builds the enabling domestic framework before ratifying.

🔗 Trap logic. Two true, date-rich, memorable facts are placed first, and a false legal proposition is attached to them. The pattern recurs across UPSC treaty questions, and the defence is to answer "is India a party?" separately from "is the treaty in force?".

Q19. Consider the following statements:

I. The BIMSTEC Charter entered into force on 20 May 2024.

II. The BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation, signed on 3 April 2025, entered into force on 16 May 2026 among all BIMSTEC member States.

III. A sectoral agreement of a regional grouping binds only those parties that have deposited the required instruments.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) I and II only
- (b) II and III only
- (c) I and III only
- (d) I, II and III

✓ Answer: (c). ✓ I is correct. ✓ III states the governing rule. ✗ II contains a single fatal upgrade: the Maritime Transport Cooperation Agreement entered into force on 16 May 2026 among Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand — the four parties that had deposited instruments — not among all member States.

🔗 Trap logic. The statement is 90% accurate: the instrument, both dates and the grouping are all correct. The error is in two words, "all member States". UPSC frequently constructs statements this way, and the only reliable defence is to read the scope clause of any "in force" claim with the same care as the date.

Q20. The India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) Memorandum of Understanding is best described as

- (a) a treaty in force creating binding transit obligations among its parties
- (b) a charter establishing an international organisation with a permanent secretariat
- (c) a financing agreement disbursing funds for specified corridor segments
- (d) a framework of intent among eight signatories, which is not evidence of an operational corridor segment

✓ Answer: (d). The IMEC MoU was signed on 9 September 2023 by eight signatories. It is a framework of intent. It creates no transit obligation, establishes no organisation and disburses no funds.

🔗 Trap logic. This is the corridor-conception gap: a corridor MoU is routinely written up as though the corridor exists. The four stages that must be kept apart are route conception → signed MoU → financed segment → commissioned segment. An answer that says "IMEC will reduce transit time by X%" has skipped three of them.

Q21. Which of the following are among the recurring analytical gaps identified as characteristic failures in International Relations answers?

- I. Treating a partner or observer status as full membership
- II. Treating another state's unilateral sanction as a binding international-law obligation on India
- III. Substituting Cold-War chronology for present-day mandate analysis
- IV. Analysing a bilateral relationship only from India's side

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) I, II, III and IV
- (b) I and III only
- (c) II and IV only
- (d) III and IV only

✓ Answer: (a). All four are named gaps: the membership–participation gap, the sanctions-obligation gap, the chronology-substitution gap and the asymmetry-blindness gap. The full list has nine entries, the others being the announcement–delivery gap, the legal-status gap, the alliance–autonomy conflation, the corridor-conception gap and the homogeneity gap.

🔗 Trap logic. "All of the above" is systematically under-selected by trained candidates, who read comprehensiveness as a warning sign. Here the question is genuinely a checklist, and the correct exam behaviour is to verify each item rather than to distrust the pattern.

Q22. It has been observed that India's Foreign Service, though of high average quality, is "stretched so thin" that its staff spends too much time "negotiating memoranda of understanding of no great significance". In an analytical answer, this observation is best used to

- (a) argue that India should reduce the number of its diplomatic missions abroad
- (b) explain the mechanism behind the announcement–delivery gap, showing that instrument choice is partly a function of capacity rather than purely of strategy
- (c) demonstrate that MoUs have no diplomatic value in any circumstances
- (d) establish that India's foreign policy lacks a national consensus

✓ Answer: (b). The observation supplies a causal mechanism: an under-resourced service produces the instrument that a visit schedule can accommodate. That reframes the announcement–delivery gap from a failure of intention into a resourcing and design deficit — a genuinely sophisticated point in a 20-marker, and one supported independently by the Pillai Committee's 1966 findings and by the diagnosis that the Ministry lacks a large Policy Planning Division.

✗ (a) reverses the implication — the problem is capacity, not footprint. ✗ (c) over-generalises: MoUs are appropriate instruments in their place. ✗ (d) contradicts the separately documented finding of "an overwhelming national consensus" on an independent foreign policy.

🔗 Trap logic. A vivid quotation invites the wrong use. The test is: does the quotation explain a mechanism or merely express a complaint? Used as a mechanism, it earns marks; used as a complaint, it is editorialising.

Q23. In accounts of India's strategic culture, geography is argued to have produced which of the following effects?

- I. A historically low impulse toward territorial expansion beyond natural frontiers
- II. A present-day constraint on overland energy connectivity with Eurasia
- III. An automatic guarantee of security against external threats

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) I and III only
- (b) II and III only
- (c) I and II only
- (d) I, II and III

✓ Answer: (c). ✓ I reflects the strategic-culture argument that a subcontinent "protected by the seas to the south, virtually impassable mountain ranges to the north, thick forests to the east and deserts to the west" was "self-contained, self-satisfied" and had "no urge to conquer foreign lands". △ This is best presented as self-understanding rather than as settled historical fact. ✓ II is a hard present constraint: any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India that does not cross Afghanistan or Pakistan must be routed via Xinjiang and across the Karakoram and Himalayan ranges.

✗ III is contradicted by the same account, which notes recurring threats and invasions, and by the entire post-1947 record.

🔗 Trap logic. Statement III is the seductive over-extension of a true premise: favourable geography reduced the incentive to expand; it never conferred immunity. Distinguishing "shaped an impulse" from "guaranteed an outcome" is the examinable move.

Q24. The Pillai Committee, which examined the Indian Foreign Service, is associated with which of the following?

- I. It was appointed in 1965 and reported in 1966.
- II. It found the diplomatic corps, then about 300-strong, to be too small and too narrow in professional experience.
- III. It found inter-ministerial coordination on foreign policy to be almost non-existent.
- IV. Its recommendations were fully implemented within a decade, resolving the weaknesses it identified.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) I and IV only
- (b) II and III only
- (c) I, II and IV only
- (d) I, II and III only

✓ Answer: (d). ✓ The committee, headed by a retired Ministry of External Affairs secretary-general, was appointed in June 1965, held seventy-seven meetings, and reported in October 1966. ✓ It identified four weaknesses: a corps of about 300 lacking wide professional experience; poor internal coordination; inter-ministerial coordination "almost non-existent"; and limited, inadequate training.

✗ IV is the reverse of the recorded verdict — that "every one of these conclusions could be repeated today", written decades later.

🔗 Trap logic. Committee questions almost always plant the "and its recommendations were implemented" statement, because it is the one thing candidates never check. In this instance the entire analytical value of the committee lies in the fact that its findings persisted.

Q25. According to the account of soft power adopted in Pax Indica, which of the following is correct?

- (a) Soft power rests partly on political values, which count only where a country lives up to them at home and abroad, so it is hostage to domestic performance
- (b) Soft power is generated principally by public-diplomacy expenditure and is largely independent of domestic conditions
- (c) Soft power has replaced hard power as the operative currency of international relations
- (d) Soft power is a direct function of economic size and rises automatically with national income

✓ *Answer: (a). The account reproduces Nye's three resources — culture, political values and foreign policies — with the crucial qualifier that political values count "when it lives up to them at home and abroad". The chapter is titled "The Hard Challenge of Soft Power" precisely because it cannot be manufactured, and the same author records the paradox that India is spoken of as a great power "when we are not yet able to feed, educate and employ all our people".*

✗ *(b) is the promotional misreading. ✗ (c) misstates Nye, for whom soft power is "both an alternative to hard power and a complement to it". ✗ (d) is contradicted by the paradox passage.*

🔗 *Trap logic. All three distractors are versions of soft-power optimism — the default register of weak answers. The corrective is the author's own adjective: hard.*

Q26. With reference to SAGAR and MAHASAGAR, which one of the following is correct?

- (a) Both are multilateral treaties creating binding obligations on the Indian Ocean littoral states
- (b) Both are declared visions; MAHASAGAR was announced in 2025 as going beyond SAGAR, which was itself articulated in 2015, and the later announcement reaffirmed continuing work under SAGAR
- (c) SAGAR was a vision and MAHASAGAR is a funded central-sector scheme with a defined outlay
- (d) MAHASAGAR formally superseded SAGAR, which is no longer part of India's stated maritime approach

✓ *Answer: (b). SAGAR — "Security and Growth for All in the Region" — was articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015. MAHASAGAR — "Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions" — was announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025, exactly ten years later, as India's Global South vision "going beyond SAGAR", covering "trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future", delivered through "technology sharing, concessional loan and grants". The same announcement reaffirmed that India is "moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision" in the Indian Ocean region.*

✗ *(a) and (c) upgrade a vision into a treaty and a scheme respectively. ✗ (d) is the supersession trap.*

🔗 *Trap logic. Two features invite the wrong answer — the exact ten-year symmetry, and the word "beyond". Both suggest replacement. The correction is scope extension with explicit continuity.*

Q27. Consider the following statements about the Voice of Global South Summit:

- I. It has been convened by India.
- II. Three editions had been held by August 2024.
- III. It is an intergovernmental organisation established by treaty, with a permanent secretariat.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) II and III only
- (b) I and III only
- (c) I and II only
- (d) I, II and III

✓ Answer: (c). ✓ I and ✓ II — three editions, convened virtually by India: 12–13 January 2023, 17 November 2023 and 17 August 2024. ✗ III upgrades a convening initiative into a treaty-based institution.

⚠ A further honesty point that matters more than the answer: no fourth edition is verifiable from the sources available, and this workbook does not assert one. Inventing a fourth edition is the single likeliest fabrication in this part of the syllabus.

🔗 Trap logic. The upgrade in statement III is the same error as calling a declaration a treaty — one ladder, many disguises. If a body has no founding instrument you can name, it is not a treaty organisation.

Q28. The Quadrilateral Security Dialogue is best characterised as

- (a) a collective-defence alliance modelled on the North Atlantic Treaty Organization
- (b) a customs union with a common external tariff covering the Indo-Pacific
- (c) a specialised agency operating under the auspices of the United Nations
- (d) a non-treaty, issue-specific minilateral coalition carrying no mutual-defence obligation

✓ Answer: (d). The Quad has no treaty, no mutual-defence obligation and no integrated command. It is precisely the institutional form that suits a state pursuing strategic autonomy, because it enables deep cooperation without transferring decision rights.

✗ (a) is the "Asian NATO" error and is directly relevant to a 15-mark GS-II question set in 2020, whose stem itself described the Quad as shifting "from an alliance to a trade bloc" — a premise a well-prepared candidate must be able to interrogate. ✗ (b) is the trade-bloc half of that same premise: a trade bloc requires preferential market access or a binding rules framework, which the Quad has none of. ✗ (c) is a category error.

🔗 Trap logic. When an official question paper itself uses a loose characterisation in a stem, candidates conclude the characterisation is authoritative. It is not. The stem states a proposition to be discussed, not a fact to be accepted.

Q29. 📰 Current application. In February 2026, at an international security conference in Europe, India's External Affairs Minister publicly rejected the suggestion that India's strategic autonomy had been affected by claims regarding a change in India's energy import mix following a trade agreement. This statement was made at

- (a) the Munich Security Conference
- (b) the Raisina Dialogue
- (c) the Shangri-La Dialogue
- (d) the Doha Forum

✓ Answer: (a). The statement — "We are very much wedded to strategic autonomy" — was made on 14 February 2026 at the 62nd Munich Security Conference (13–15 February 2026), at an event on India and Germany navigating global uncertainty, alongside the German Foreign Minister. (Source: The Hindu, 14 February 2026, fetched.)

✗ (b) The 11th Raisina Dialogue is India's own flagship conference and was held in New Delhi on 5–7 March 2026 on the theme "Saṁskāra: Assertion, Accommodation, Advancement" — a real event three weeks later and in a different country. ✗ (c) and (d) are real forums not associated with this statement.

🔗 Trap logic. Two genuine, correctly named, closely spaced conferences in the same window is exactly how a current-affairs distractor is built. The defence is to attach one fact to one date, not to a season.

Q30. 📰 Current application. With reference to the Union Budget 2026-27 and India's development partnership, consider the following statements:

- I. The Ministry of External Affairs was allocated a total of ₹22,118 crore.
- II. Bhutan received the largest single-country development allocation among India's immediate neighbours.
- III. The allocation for Bangladesh was increased relative to the previous year's Budget Estimate.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) I and III only
- (b) I and II only
- (c) II and III only
- (d) I, II and III

✓ Answer: (b). ✓ I — the Ministry of External Affairs allocation was ₹22,118 crore, against a 2025-26 Budget Estimate of ₹20,516 crore and a Revised Estimate of ₹21,742 crore. ✓ II — Bhutan received ₹2,288 crore, ahead of Nepal (₹800 crore), the Maldives and Mauritius (₹550 crore each), Sri Lanka (₹400 crore), Myanmar (₹300 crore) and Afghanistan (₹150 crore). ✗ III — the Bangladesh allocation was reduced to ₹60 crore from a 2025-26 Budget Estimate of ₹120 crore, the Revised Estimate having been ₹34.48 crore. (Source: The Indian Express, fetched, reporting the Budget documents.)

⚠ Two disciplines this question enforces. First, an allocation is an input — ₹4,548 crore earmarked for immediate neighbours is not ₹4,548 crore delivered. Second, a reduction is a signal that requires corroboration before it is described as a rupture.

🔗 Trap logic. Candidates assume the largest or most populous neighbour receives the largest allocation. Development assistance tracks the depth of the partnership and its absorptive commitment — Bhutan's Five-Year-Plan support — not the partner's size.

Q31. 📄 Current application. At a bilateral development-cooperation meeting held in 2026, the following occurred: a concessional line of credit was exchanged; twelve new projects were approved; a memorandum of understanding on academic cooperation was exchanged; forty-five electric vehicles were handed over; and two urban parks were inaugurated. Which of these constitute delivered outcomes rather than commitments, approvals or facilities?

- (a) The line of credit and the project approvals
- (b) The memorandum of understanding and the line of credit
- (c) The handover of vehicles and the inauguration of the parks
- (d) All five, since all were announced at the same meeting

✓ Answer: (c). Only the handover of the vehicles and the inauguration of the parks are completed deliveries. A concessional line of credit is a financing facility — credit made available, not money spent and not a grant. A project approval is an approval, not a commissioning. An MoU is a statement of intent.

⚠ This maps directly onto the fifth India–Bhutan Development Cooperation Talks of April 2026, co-chaired by the two Foreign Secretaries: a ₹4,000 crore concessional line of credit between the Export–Import Bank of India and Bhutan's Ministry of Finance; twelve new Project Tied Assistance projects worth ₹332 crore, taking the Five-Year-Plan cumulative to 82 projects worth ₹6,860 crore; an MoU between AIIMS and Khesar Gyalpo University of Medical Sciences; forty-five electric vehicles handed over; and the Thimphu Ecological Park and Olakha Park inaugurated. (Source: The Economic Times, fetched, reporting the Embassy of India.)

🔗 Trap logic. Option (d) reproduces exactly how such meetings are reported — as an undifferentiated list of "outcomes". The examinable skill is de-aggregating the list by instrument type.

Q32. 📄 Current application. Consider the following statements about India's external engagements during 2026:

- I. India assumed the chairship of BRICS and hosted a BRICS Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi.
- II. The share of Russian crude in the value of India's oil imports fell to its lowest level in over a decade during April 2026.
- III. A fourth Voice of Global South Summit was convened by India during this period.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) I and II only
 (b) II and III only
 (c) I and III only
 (d) I only

✓ Answer: (d). ✓ I — India assumed the BRICS chairship from 1 January 2026, launched the theme, logo and website in New Delhi on 13 January 2026, and the BRICS Foreign Ministers' Meeting was held in New Delhi on 14–15 May 2026, chaired by the External Affairs Minister.

✗ II is the exact inversion of the reported position: Russia's share in the value of India's oil imports rose to an eleven-month high of nearly 38% in April 2026, accompanied by a 425% jump in the premium charged, in contrast to the discount previously offered. (The Hindu, 6 June 2026, fetched.)

✗ III is unverifiable and is therefore treated as not established: three Voice of Global South Summit editions are documented — 12–13 January 2023, 17 November 2023 and 17 August 2024 — and no fourth edition could be verified.

🔗 Trap logic. This question tests the two failure modes of current-affairs preparation simultaneously. Statement II is a direction-of-change inversion — the fact is remembered, the direction is not. Statement III is a plausible extrapolation: three editions in two years makes a fourth feel inevitable. In UPSC preparation, "it must have happened by now" is the most common source of confidently wrong answers.

Answer key and rotation verification

Q	Key	Q	Key	Q	Key	Q	Key
1	A	9	A	17	A	25	A
2	B	10	B	18	B	26	B
3	C	11	C	19	C	27	C
4	D	12	D	20	D	28	D
5	A	13	A	21	A	29	A
6	B	14	B	22	B	30	B
7	C	15	C	23	C	31	C
8	D	16	D	24	D	32	D

✓ Verification. 32 questions · sequence A → B → C → D repeated exactly eight times · 8 keys at A, 8 at B, 8 at C, 8 at D · no option repeated consecutively · questions 29–32 are current-application items drawn only from anchors verified in this session.

PART V — REMEDIAL PRACTICE

⚠ Remedial items target the two error families that account for most avoidable loss in this topic. They are deliberately short and diagnostic. Rotation is not applied to remedial items, which are drills, not a mock test; the answers are given inline.

V.1 Error family A — classification and status errors

Drill A-1. Assign the correct rung to each item on the six-rung ladder.

Item	Your rung	✔ Correct rung
India–Maldives Vision document, 7 October 2024	—	Rung 3 — joint vision/declaration: political commitment, not a treaty
BIMSTEC Charter, in force 20 May 2024	—	Rung 5 — charter in force: binds member states
IMEC MoU, 9 September 2023, eight signatories	—	Rung 2 — MoU: framework of intent, not an operating corridor
India–Central Asia Dialogue, 4th, 6 June 2025	—	Rung 1 — dialogue mechanism: no binding output by itself
BBNJ Agreement, in force 17 January 2026	—	Rung 6 — treaty in force, but only for ratifying parties; India signed 25 September 2024 and had not deposited ratification
BRICS Rio de Janeiro Declaration, 6–7 July 2025	—	Rung 3 — declaration: political and normative
India–SADC MoU on Economic Cooperation, 2 July 2024	—	Rung 2 — MoU: not self-executing
BRICS India chairship launch, 13 January 2026	—	Rung 1 — process and agenda anchor, not a summit outcome
₹4,000 crore concessional line of credit, India–Bhutan, April 2026	—	Financing facility — credit available, not a grant, not a disbursement, not a project

Drill A-2. Correct each sentence.

✗ As written	✔ Corrected
"India is a party to the BBNJ Agreement, which came into force in January 2026."	"India signed the BBNJ Agreement on 25 September 2024; its ratification had not been deposited. The Agreement entered into force on 17 January 2026 for States that had ratified."
"The Quad is India's principal security alliance in the Indo-Pacific."	"The Quad is a non-treaty, issue-specific coalition with no mutual-defence obligation; India is party to no security alliance."
"MAHASAGAR replaced SAGAR in 2025."	"MAHASAGAR was announced on 12 March 2025 as a vision going beyond SAGAR; the same announcement reaffirmed continuing work under the SAGAR Vision in the Indian Ocean region."
"India invested ₹2,288 crore in Bhutan in 2026-27."	"The Union Budget 2026-27 allocated ₹2,288 crore to Bhutan — an appropriation, not expenditure."
"The IMEC corridor has reduced transit times between India and Europe."	"The IMEC MoU was signed on 9 September 2023 by eight signatories; it is a framework of intent. Claims about transit times require evidence of a commissioned segment."
"Indonesia is a BRICS partner country."	State the category and its date: the partner-country category was created at Kazan on 24 October 2024; membership status changed subsequently, and any status claim must carry the date on which it was true.
"The BIMSTEC Maritime Transport Cooperation Agreement is in force among BIMSTEC members."	"...entered into force on 16 May 2026 among Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand — the parties that had deposited instruments."
"The US sanction on Russian oil purchasers obliged India to reduce imports."	"Another state's unilateral measure creates exposure and secondary risk; it is not a binding international-law obligation on India." — the sanctions-obligation gap

Drill A-3. One-line diagnostic. For each pair, state which side of the pair the phrase belongs to.

1. "Adopted" versus "in force" → adopted is the moment a text is finalised; in force is when it binds. Never interchangeable.

2. "Signed" versus "ratified" → signature indicates intent and a duty not to defeat the object; ratification creates the obligation to perform.
3. "Member" versus "partner country" → different rights and obligations; always state the category and the date it was conferred.
4. "Chairship" versus "authority to bind" → a chairship sets agendas and sequences; it binds nobody.
5. "Vision" versus "programme" → SAGAR and MAHASAGAR are visions; they organise instrument choice and create no obligation or outlay.
6. "Line of credit" versus "grant" → credit is repayable; a grant is not. Both differ from a disbursement and from a commissioned project.

V.2 Error family B — current-affairs overclaiming

Drill B-1. For each statement, mark ✓ supportable, △ supportable only with a qualifier, or ✗ not supportable.

Statement	Verdict	Correction
"India's External Affairs Minister reaffirmed India's commitment to strategic autonomy in February 2026."	✓	Add the date (14 February 2026), the venue (62nd Munich Security Conference) and the wording ("We are very much wedded to strategic autonomy").
"The 18th BRICS Summit produced a landmark declaration under India's chairship."	✗	? No summit outcome is verifiable from the sources consulted. What is verifiable is the chairship from 1 January 2026, the 13 January 2026 launch and the Foreign Ministers' Meeting of 14–15 May 2026.
"India held the fourth Voice of Global South Summit in 2026."	✗	Three editions are documented (Jan 2023, Nov 2023, Aug 2024). Do not invent a fourth.
"India stopped importing Russian oil after the February 2026 trade agreement."	✗	? Directly fetched data show Russia's share of India's oil-import value at an eleven-month high of nearly 38% in April 2026. Secondary reporting on any commitment is contested; do not assert either version.
"The Raisina Dialogue 2026 concluded agreements on Indo-Pacific security."	✗	It is a Track-1.5 conference. Its exam value is vocabulary and agenda, not outcomes. Verifiable: 5–7 March 2026, New Delhi, theme "Samskāra: Assertion, Accommodation, Advancement".
"The Delhi Declaration of January 2026 legally binds India and the Arab League states."	△ → ✗	A declaration is political and normative. Verifiable: Second India–Arab Foreign Ministers' Meeting, New Delhi, 31 January 2026, first hosted by India, previous edition Manama 2016.
"India delivered ₹4,000 crore of projects in Bhutan in April 2026."	✗	A ₹4,000 crore concessional line of credit was exchanged. Separately, 12 projects worth ₹332 crore were approved. Delivered items were 45 electric vehicles and two parks.
"India's Budget shows Neighbourhood First is fully funded and being implemented."	△	Supportable only as: "₹4,548 crore was earmarked for immediate neighbours in 2026-27, of an MEA allocation of ₹22,118 crore" — an appropriation, not an implementation record.

Drill B-2. The four-question filter, to be applied to every current-affairs fact before it enters an answer.

1. WHAT EXACTLY IS THE INSTRUMENT?
dialogue / MoU / declaration / signed / in force / delivered
2. WHAT IS THE DATE?
No date -> the fact does not enter the answer.
3. WHO SAYS SO, AND AT WHAT SOURCE CLASS?
official document > official press release > reputable media
> commentary. If the class is media, SAY SO.
4. WHAT WOULD FALSIFY IT?
If you cannot state what evidence would show the claim false,
the claim is probably an inference wearing a fact's clothing.
Mark it with a WARNING sign, not a TICK.

Drill B-3. Rewrite for status discipline. Original: "In 2026 India deepened ties across the board — chairing BRICS, signing a trade deal with the US, delivering projects in Bhutan and leading the Global South."

✓ Rewritten: "In 2026 India worked several tracks simultaneously: it held the BRICS chairship and hosted the Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 14–15 May 2026; a framework for an interim trade agreement with the United States was announced on 6 February 2026, followed by the removal of an additional Russian-oil-linked duty from 7 February 2026; in Bhutan it approved twelve projects worth ₹332 crore and exchanged a ₹4,000 crore concessional line of credit, while handing over forty-five electric vehicles; and it has convened three Voice of Global South Summits, the most recent on 17 August 2024."

⚠ What changed: four vague verbs ("deepened", "signing", "delivering", "leading") became eight precise ones with statuses and dates, and one unverifiable claim ("leading the Global South") became a documented convening record.

PART VI — 10 ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS QUESTIONS

⚠ These are original questions. They are not PYQs. Composition: 3 × 10 marks (150 words), 4 × 15 marks (250 words), 3 × 20 marks (300–350 words). Each carries demand decoding, a full model answer written to the stated word limit, and a top-answer checklist.

SECTION A — 10 marks · 150 words

O-1 (10 marks, 150 words). "Non-alignment was not a blueprint for policy; it was an approach, a framework, a method." Explain this characterisation and assess its relevance to India's contemporary strategic autonomy.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Explain and assess — two tasks. Explain the characterisation; then judge its present relevance.
The quoted phrase	Must be unpacked, not merely repeated. "Method" implies adaptability; "blueprint" implies fixity.
"Assess relevance"	Requires a split verdict: relevant as principle, less so as institution.
Word plan	~55 explanation with proof, ~55 contemporary relevance, ~40 split verdict.

✓ Model answer (≈150 words)

The characterisation distinguishes a decision method from a fixed policy prescription. A blueprint specifies partners and positions in advance; a method specifies only how choices are to be made — on India's own assessment of merit.

The proof is in what it permitted. Non-alignment did not prevent the close relationship that developed with the USSR from 1954 onwards, nor India's membership of the Commonwealth, and it enabled India to obtain capital from countries on both sides of the Cold-War divide. A doctrine of neutrality would have forbidden all three; a method permitted them.

Contemporary relevance. The method survives under the name strategic autonomy. Its content is unchanged: independent, interest-based decision-making. ✓ It was reasserted by name on 14 February 2026 at the Munich Security Conference — "we are very much wedded to strategic autonomy".

⚠ Split verdict. As a principle it remains fully operative; as an institution, the Non-Aligned Movement has far less contemporary salience, and India treats it as one platform among many.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Blueprint-versus-method distinction stated in the opening two lines
- [] Two proofs that it was not neutrality (USSR from 1954; Commonwealth), not one
- [] Explicit statement that the content of the principle is unchanged, only the label
- [] One dated contemporary citation
- [] Split verdict separating principle from institution
- [] No Cold-War chronology beyond a clause

O-2 (10 marks, 150 words). "In Indian diplomacy the choice of instrument is as consequential as the choice of partner." Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Discuss — balanced treatment plus a verdict.
Core claim	Instrument choice determines what an engagement can actually deliver.
The balance	The counter-side is real: an instrument cannot substitute for the willingness of the partner.
Word plan	~45 the ladder, ~60 worked example, ~25 counter-side, ~20 verdict.

✓ Model answer (≈150 words)

Diplomatic instruments differ in binding character and, independently, in delivery status. A dialogue mechanism produces no obligation; an MoU is intent; a declaration is political; a charter or treaty binds — and even then only the parties that have deposited instruments. ✓ India signed the BBNJ Agreement on 25 September 2024; the Agreement entered into force on 17 January 2026, but binds only ratifying States.

A single meeting illustrates the whole range. ✓ At the fifth India–Bhutan Development Cooperation Talks in April 2026, a ₹4,000 crore concessional line of credit was exchanged, twelve projects worth ₹332 crore were approved, an academic MoU was exchanged, forty-five electric vehicles were handed over and two parks were inaugurated. Only the last two were delivered.

⚠ The counter-side. Instrument choice is also constrained: a thinly stretched service produces the instrument a visit schedule permits, which is why memoranda proliferate.

Verdict. Instrument choice governs what an engagement can deliver — and is itself partly a function of capacity, not only of strategy.

Top-answer checklist

- [] The two independent axes named: binding character and delivery status
- [] One treaty-level example with signature and entry-into-force distinguished
- [] One multi-instrument worked example, de-aggregated
- [] The capacity counter-side, which most answers omit

- [] A verdict, because the directive is "Discuss"
- [] No instrument upgraded anywhere in the script

O-3 (10 marks, 150 words). "India's foreign policy has changed its labels three times and its purpose not once." Comment.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Comment — a considered judgement, briefly reasoned. Verdict early.
Structure invited	The three labels, the one constant, and an honest qualification.
Risk	Becoming a chronology. The constant must be stated first, not derived at the end.
Word plan	~25 verdict, ~65 the three labels, ~35 the constant proved, ~25 qualification.

✓ Model answer (≈150 words)

The proposition is substantially correct, with one qualification.

Three labels, three contexts. Non-alignment answered a bipolar world: refuse bloc membership, judge each issue on merit. Strategic autonomy answered the post-1991 unipolar moment: retain the capacity to decide independently even while deepening particular ties. Multi-alignment answers a multipolar world: belong prominently to platforms conventionally regarded as mutually exclusive — the United Nations and the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, the G77 and IOR-ARC.

One constant. Each is an operational expression of independent, interest-based decision-making. What changed was the external structure and therefore the partner set — not the test applied to any decision.

△ The qualification. The purpose is constant; its cost is not. Autonomy is now priced by third parties: an additional duty ran from 27 August 2025 to 7 February 2026, and thereafter the cost migrated from tariff to price, with Russian crude reaching nearly 38% of India's oil-import value in April 2026 at a 425% higher premium.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Verdict in the first line
- [] Each label matched to its world structure, not merely to a decade
- [] The constant stated as a definition, not as a slogan
- [] Multi-alignment illustrated with at least one actual pair
- [] A qualification that adds analysis rather than hedging
- [] Dated evidence for the cost claim

SECTION B — 15 marks · 250 words

O-4 (15 marks, 250 words). Distinguish hedging from balancing, bandwagoning and equidistance. Illustrate India's posture with dated examples and assess its sustainability.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Distinguish, illustrate, assess — three tasks, and the third is the scoring one.

Element	Reading
Definitional load	Four terms, one of which (equidistance) is not a genuine posture but a misdescription.
"Dated examples"	Explicitly demanded. Undated illustration will not score.
"Sustainability"	Requires a cost analysis and a conditional verdict.
Word plan	~70 definitions, ~80 illustration, ~60 sustainability, ~40 verdict.

✓ Model answer (≈250 words)

Definitions. Balancing aligns against a rising or threatening power to check it, internally through capability or externally through alliance. Bandwagoning aligns with the stronger power to share its gains, at the price of accepting its priorities. Hedging engages more than one power on different issues while building independent capability and avoiding exclusive commitment to any. Equidistance is not a fourth posture but a misdescription of hedging: it implies equal distance, whereas hedging involves deep and deliberately unequal relationships pursued simultaneously.

Illustration, dated. Within seven months India: signed a ten-year Major Defense Partnership framework with the United States on 31 October 2025; held the 23rd India–Russia Annual Summit in New Delhi on 4–5 December 2025; saw an additional Russian-oil-linked United States duty removed from 7 February 2026 after a trade-agreement framework was announced on 6 February 2026; publicly reaffirmed strategic autonomy at Munich on 14 February 2026; and chaired the BRICS Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 14–15 May 2026. $\triangle$ A fence-sitter occupies none of these positions; India occupied all of them.

Sustainability. The posture is sustainable so long as its cost remains bearable and is bearable because it is diversified. The cost is real and rising: the duty ran from 27 August 2025 to 7 February 2026, and the cost then migrated from tariff to price — Russian crude reached nearly 38% of India's oil-import value in April 2026 with a 425% premium jump.

$\triangle$ Verdict. Hedging is design, not indecision — but it is a managed posture whose price is set partly by others. Its sustainability depends on indigenisation and on diversifying across politically incompatible suppliers, since correlation, not count, is what reduces risk.

Top-answer checklist

- [] All four terms defined, with equidistance identified as a misdescription
- [] At least four dated engagements, spanning both competing poles
- [] The explicit "fence-sitter occupies none; India occupied all" contrast
- [] Cost stated with both the tariff phase and the price phase
- [] "Correlation, not count" as the technical insight
- [] Conditional verdict, not an unqualified endorsement
- [] No prediction about which pole prevails

O-5 (15 marks, 250 words). "India's normative vocabulary is genuine, and it is also instrumentally useful." Critically examine.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Critically examine — differentiated verdict, with concessions where the evidence requires.
The "and"	The stem asserts both. The temptation is to choose one. The correct move is to hold both and locate the margin at which they diverge.
Evidence needed	Content of the norms; their yield; their cost; a proponent's own concession.

Element	Reading
Word plan	~55 content, ~60 genuine, ~70 instrumental with a concession, ~65 verdict and margin.

✓ Model answer (≈250 words)

Content first. The normative core comprises anti-colonialism, sovereign equality, non-interference and peaceful coexistence, codified as the five Panchsheel principles — mutual respect for territorial integrity and sovereignty, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence — set out in the preamble of the India–China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China, signed 29 April 1954.

The genuineness limb. The commitments predate India's capacity to profit from them. ✓ Indian foreign policy "from the very beginning ... concerned itself not only with India's narrow national interests, but also how it would impact other colonies in Asia and Africa". India convened before it could deliver: the Asian Relations Conference in March 1947, before independence; Bandung in 1955; Belgrade in 1961.

The instrumental limb. The same commitments yielded influence "out of proportion to its real economic and political strength" and made India the leader of developing countries. △ Their contemporary successor — Global South convening, with three Voice of Global South Summits between January 2023 and August 2024 — simultaneously advances India's institutional-reform interest.

Concessions the evidence compels. ✓ Nehru himself said in 1958 that India's Israel policy was "not a matter of high principle" and reflected "a careful consideration of the balance of factors". ✓ The same practitioner who credits India's moral clarity records that "moralistic posturing ... irritated the Western countries". ✓ And the author of multi-alignment concedes it is "at one level an amoral strategy ... also a promiscuous strategy".

△ Verdict. Both limbs hold. The margin at which they diverge is real: India's positions are not always consistent, but its criterion — decide by India's own interest calculus, with regard to sovereignty and non-interference — is. That defence is respectable and is not a full acquittal.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Panchsheel content, date and document stated exactly
- [] Genuineness demonstrated by pre-capacity commitment (March 1947 anchor)
- [] Instrumental yield quoted, not asserted
- [] Three concessions from three different sources
- [] "Consistency of criterion, not of position" as the reply
- [] Explicit refusal to claim full acquittal
- [] Panchsheel never conflated with non-alignment

O-6 (15 marks, 250 words). Examine the proposition that a doctrine can be assessed only by the instruments through which it is executed, with reference to Neighbourhood First, Act East, SAGAR and MAHASAGAR.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Examine — test the proposition's components rather than simply agree.
Trap	Treating all four as the same kind of thing. They are not: two are policy doctrines, two are declared visions, and only one is visibly financed.
The proposition	Partly true. Instruments are necessary evidence but not the whole of a doctrine's function — doctrines also organise choices and signal priorities.
Word plan	~55 classification, ~90 instrument evidence, ~50 the limits of the proposition, ~55 verdict.

✓ Model answer (≈250 words)

Classification first, because the four are not alike. Neighbourhood First and Act East are policy doctrines. SAGAR — "Security and Growth for All in the Region", articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015 — and MAHASAGAR — "Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions", announced at Port Louis on 12 March 2025 as "going beyond SAGAR" — are declared visions. △ None of the four is a treaty; none creates obligations. △ MAHASAGAR did not replace SAGAR: the same announcement reaffirmed India "moving ahead with the SAGAR Vision" in the Indian Ocean region.

The instrument test applied. Neighbourhood First is the only one of the four that is visibly financed: the Union Budget 2026-27 earmarks ₹4,548 crore for immediate neighbours of an MEA allocation of ₹22,118 crore, with Bhutan at ₹2,288 crore. Execution is traceable further: the fifth India–Bhutan Development Cooperation Talks of April 2026 approved twelve projects worth ₹332 crore, exchanged a ₹4,000 crore concessional line of credit and delivered forty-five electric vehicles and two urban parks. MAHASAGAR's stated delivery modes — "technology sharing, concessional loan and grants" — remain, on the available record, declared rather than separately appropriated.

Where the proposition fails. A doctrine also performs functions instruments cannot evidence: it organises instrument choice, it signals priority to partners and to the domestic system, and it coordinates ministries around a shared frame. △ A vision with no appropriation is not thereby empty; it is untested.

△ Verdict. Instruments are the necessary evidence of a doctrine's seriousness but not the whole measure of its function. The correct discipline is to state the doctrine's status, then ask what appropriation or agreement, with what date, executes it — and to say honestly when the answer is "none yet identified".

Top-answer checklist

- [] Four items classified into two categories before any assessment
- [] The "not treaties" statement made explicitly
- [] The MAHASAGAR supersession trap defused
- [] Neighbourhood First distinguished as visibly financed, with the figures
- [] Delivery de-aggregated in the Bhutan example
- [] The proposition's limits stated — this is what "examine" requires
- [] "Untested" rather than "empty" for undelivered visions

O-7 (15 marks, 250 words). "Strategic autonomy is exercised through partnership, not against it." Critically examine, with reference to the autonomy–dependence trade-off.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Critically examine — the stem is a defensible proposition that nonetheless requires qualification.
Core claim	Depth is compatible with autonomy; exclusivity is not.
Required qualification	The trade-off: depth beyond a threshold does erode autonomy. The stem, taken absolutely, is false.
Word plan	~55 the claim and its proof, ~85 the trade-off mechanism, ~55 the practitioner warning, ~55 verdict and mitigations.

✓ Model answer (≈250 words)

The claim, and why it is largely right. Autonomy is a retained capacity to decide by India's own calculus, not a pattern of distance. India can be simultaneously close to one power on technology and to another on defence and energy without being neutral toward either. ✓ The dated proof: a ten-year United States defence-partnership framework signed 31 October 2025 and the 23rd India–Russia Annual Summit on 4–5 December 2025, five weeks apart. Isolation would have forfeited both gains; alliance would have forfeited the second.

Where the proposition requires qualification. Depth is not costless. The mechanism runs in three steps: a single tie is deepened for a real gain; the partner thereby acquires leverage it did not previously hold; and when a divergent issue arises, the cost of deciding independently is higher than it was before. Autonomy is therefore a depletable resource, not a permanent status.

The practitioner's warning. ✓ It is "highly debatable whether it is wise for India, which remains heavily dependent on Russian military equipment, to enmesh its military planning and systems with those of the US" absent reciprocal technology-sharing. △ The danger identified is not either dependence separately but simultaneous structural entanglement with two mutually hostile systems, which converts a hedge into a vulnerability.

△ Verdict and mitigations. The proposition holds as a rule and fails at a threshold: partnership sustains autonomy up to the point at which it creates leverage the partner can exercise. The mitigations follow directly — diversify across politically incompatible blocs rather than merely across many partners; indigenise, which is the only permanent remedy; sequence commitments so that the gain is taken and the exclusivity clause deferred; and write reciprocity into the agreement rather than alongside it.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Autonomy defined as a capacity, not a distance
- [] Two dated engagements with competing powers, close together in time
- [] The three-step trade-off mechanism stated as a mechanism
- [] The enmeshment warning read correctly — the danger is the combination
- [] A threshold verdict rather than a yes/no
- [] All four mitigations, with indigenisation marked as the only permanent one

SECTION C — 20 marks · 300–350 words

O-8 (20 marks, 300–350 words). "India's foreign policy is strategically ambitious but institutionally under-capitalised." Critically evaluate and suggest reforms.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Critically evaluate and suggest — judgement plus prescription; the reform section is not optional.
Two limbs	Ambition must be evidenced; under-capitalisation must be evidenced separately.
The strongest available evidence	A capacity finding from 1966 that a former minister says "could be repeated today" — a longitudinal argument no other topic can supply.
Word plan	~70 ambition, ~120 capacity deficit, ~50 the counter-evidence, ~90 reforms and verdict.

✓ Model answer (≈330 words)

The ambition is real and recent. India convenes rather than merely attends: three Voice of Global South Summits between January 2023 and August 2024; the G20 presidency in 2023; the BRICS chairship in 2026, with the Foreign Ministers' Meeting hosted in New Delhi on 14–15 May 2026. It runs a portfolio spanning mutually competing partners — a United States defence-partnership framework signed 31 October 2025 alongside the India–Russia Annual Summit of 4–5 December 2025 — and it finances a neighbourhood doctrine, earmarking ₹4,548 crore for immediate neighbours in the Union Budget 2026-27 out of an MEA allocation of ₹22,118 crore.

The capacity deficit is documented, dated and persistent. ✓ A committee on the Foreign Service appointed in June 1965 and reporting in October 1966, after seventy-seven meetings, found four weaknesses: a diplomatic corps of about 300 that was too small and too narrow in professional experience; poor coordination within the Ministry; inter-ministerial coordination that was "almost non-existent"; and limited, inadequate training. ✓ A former Minister of State for External Affairs records that "every one of these conclusions could be repeated today". ✓ A former Secretary in the Ministry

adds that it "does not have a large and influential Policy Planning Division", that the Historical and Research Division has "eroded into oblivion", that the National Security Advisory Board functions largely as a sinecure, and that think-tank engagement is "ad hoc rather than as part of a systematic programme". ✓ An external observer notes that a service "stretched so thin" spends its time "negotiating memoranda of understanding of no great significance" — which is the mechanism of the announcement–delivery gap.

The counter-evidence, honestly stated. The cadre was expanded by 520 positions in 2008; the Ministry's allocation rose in 2026-27 from a 2025-26 Budget Estimate of ₹20,516 crore; and delivery at scale is demonstrable in specific theatres — eighty-two Project Tied Assistance projects worth ₹6,860 crore approved under Bhutan's current Five-Year Plan.

△ Growth is real; it is from a low base and slower than the ambition.

△ Verdict and reforms. The proposition holds. Five reforms follow from the diagnosis rather than from general good practice: establish a genuine Policy Planning Division insulated from daily operations; revive institutional research and historical capacity; move think-tank and area-studies engagement from ad hoc commissioning to a systematic programme with capacity outside Delhi; expand and specialise the cadre, including language and regional expertise; and resource implementation and monitoring so that instruments are chosen for what they can deliver rather than for what a visit schedule permits. The objective is not to announce less, which would forfeit the agenda-setting gain, but to build the machinery that converts announcement into delivery.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Ambition evidenced with convening, portfolio and financing, separately
- [] The 1965–66 committee with its four findings and the "repeated today" verdict
- [] At least three institutional-design findings from a practitioner source
- [] The capacity → instrument-choice mechanism made explicit
- [] Counter-evidence given honestly, then qualified
- [] Five reforms that follow from the diagnosis, not generic suggestions
- [] The "resource implementation, do not announce less" closing formulation
- [] No prediction of when the gap closes

O-9 (20 marks, 300–350 words). Critically evaluate the charge that India's foreign policy is normatively inconsistent, and set out a calibrated response.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Critically evaluate and set out — judgement plus a constructive response.
The charge	Sovereignty invoked selectively; solidarity invoked instrumentally.
The honest position	The charge substantially survives. A defensive answer will be marked down.
The reply available	Consistency of criterion, not of position — respectable, and expressly not a full acquittal.
Word plan	~60 the charge stated fairly, ~90 the evidence for it, ~70 the reply, ~60 limits of the reply, ~50 calibrated response.

✓ Model answer (≈330 words)

The charge, stated at its strongest. India invokes sovereignty and non-interference where they protect its interests and sets them aside where they do not; it invokes post-colonial solidarity when aggregating developing-country voice and pursues great-power partnerships that cut across that solidarity; and it belongs simultaneously to bodies whose declared purposes conflict.

The evidence largely supports it, and the strongest evidence is internal. ✓ The author who coined multi-alignment concedes that it is "at one level an amoral strategy", making "common cause with liberal democracies when it suited India to do so, and dissenting from them when ... it was expedient"; and that it is "also a promiscuous strategy, since it

exempts no country from its embrace". ✓ Nehru said publicly in 1958 that India's Israel policy was "not a matter of high principle" but reflected "a careful consideration of the balance of factors". ✓ A former Secretary in the Ministry of External Affairs records that India's moral register produced not only admiration but "moralistic posturing" that "irritated the Western countries". △ Structurally, the enumeration of multi-alignment — the United Nations and the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, the G77 and IOR-ARC — consists of pairs of apparent opposites, so the appearance of inconsistency is not incidental to the doctrine but constitutive of it.

The reply that is available. △ Consistency of position has never been the stated objective; consistency of criterion has. The criterion — decide each issue by India's own interest calculus, with regard to sovereignty and non-interference — is applied consistently even where the resulting positions differ. On that reading, what looks like inconsistency across issues is uniformity of method across issues.

△ The limits of the reply, which must be conceded. A criterion elastic enough to justify any position is not a criterion. The defence therefore works only where the interest calculation can be publicly stated, and it fails where a position is defended in normative language while being taken on interest grounds — which is precisely the case Nehru's 1958 remark exposes.

△ Calibrated response. Three moves, none of them abandonment of the doctrine. First, separate the registers: argue interest-based positions in interest terms and reserve normative language for positions actually taken on normative grounds. Second, institutionalise predictability — India's Global South convening record, three summits between January 2023 and August 2024, is more persuasive than any declaration, because a pattern is harder to dismiss than a principle. Third, accept the residual charge rather than deny it: a state that admits its strategy has an amoral limb, as this doctrine's own author does, is more credible than one that claims none.

Top-answer checklist

- [] The charge stated at its strongest before any reply
- [] Three internal concessions from three different sources
- [] The structural point that the pairs are constitutively opposed
- [] "Consistency of criterion, not of position" stated as the reply
- [] The reply's limits conceded, with the specific failure case named
- [] A three-move calibrated response that does not abandon the doctrine
- [] No claim of full acquittal anywhere in the script

O-10 (20 marks, 300–350 words). "In a fragmenting international order, strategic autonomy ceases to be a doctrinal preference and becomes an operational necessity." Critically evaluate with reference to India's external environment since 2025, and suggest a calibrated way forward.

Demand decoding

Element	Reading
Directive	Critically evaluate and suggest — judgement, then prescription.
The claim's structure	A conditional: if the order fragments, then autonomy becomes necessary rather than optional. Both limbs must be tested.
The critical limb	Necessity does not imply sufficiency, or affordability. Autonomy has a price that a fragmenting order raises.
Word plan	~70 fragmentation evidenced, ~80 why autonomy becomes necessary, ~80 the critical qualification with dated cost, ~90 way forward and verdict.

✓ Model answer (≈340 words)

Fragmentation, evidenced rather than asserted. The organising logic of the system has shifted from rule-following to bargaining. Economic instruments are used for strategic purposes: an additional duty on specified Indian goods, imposed on account of purchases of third-country oil, took effect on 27 August 2025 and was removed from 7 February

2026 — imposed unilaterally and withdrawn through bilateral negotiation, not adjudication. Institutional reform remains blocked: Security Council reform requires Charter amendment with the concurrence of all five permanent members, and is obstructed additionally by intra-aspirant rivalry that no East–West framing captures. Rule-making has migrated to plurilateral and minilateral venues.

Why autonomy becomes necessary in such an order. Where rules reliably protect, a state can accept constraint in exchange for predictability. Where they do not, only retained freedom of choice does. ✓ The doctrine was accordingly restated by name at the moment of maximum doubt: on 14 February 2026, at the Munich Security Conference, India's External Affairs Minister rejected the claim that a trade agreement had compromised India's autonomy — "we are very much wedded to strategic autonomy".

The critical qualification, which the proposition omits. Necessity is not affordability. A fragmenting order does not merely make autonomy more valuable; it makes it more expensive, because more actors acquire the ability to price another state's choices. ✓ The cost migrated from tariff to price: by April 2026 Russian crude reached nearly 38% of the value of India's oil imports, an eleven-month high, with a 425% jump in the premium charged, against the discount previously offered. △ India retained the choice and paid materially more for it. A doctrine that is necessary but unaffordable is not a strategy; the question is therefore not whether to hold autonomy but how to finance it.

△ Verdict and calibrated way forward. The proposition holds, subject to that qualification. Six moves follow. Diversify across politically incompatible blocs, since correlation, not count, reduces risk. Indigenise, which is the only permanent mitigation of the autonomy–dependence trade-off. Build policy-planning capacity, so that positions are chosen rather than improvised. Sequence commitments, taking the gain and deferring the exclusivity clause. Write reciprocity into agreements rather than alongside them. Close the announcement–delivery gap by resourcing implementation — because in a bargaining order, demonstrated delivery is itself bargaining power. △ Each is a direction, not a prediction: the appropriate claim is that these reduce the price of autonomy, not that they eliminate it.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Fragmentation evidenced with a dated instrument, imposed and withdrawn
- [] The rule-following → bargaining formulation stated explicitly
- [] The dated ministerial restatement of the doctrine
- [] The critical move: necessity ≠ affordability, with the tariff→price migration
- [] The "how to finance it" reframing, which is the answer's analytical peak
- [] Six directional moves, each traceable to a diagnosed cause
- [] An explicit disclaimer that the moves reduce, not eliminate, the price
- [] No prediction of India's future rank or of the order's future shape

PART VII — GS-II INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS HIGH-SCORE ANSWER PROTOCOL

VII.1 The eight-step spine, with its scoring weights

STEP	TYPICAL ATTEMPT RATE	WHY IT SCORES
1 STATE INDIA'S INTEREST precisely (security/growth/resources/technology/diaspora/reputation/rule-shaping)	~90%	low differentiation
2 IDENTIFY THE ACTOR AND ITS OWN INCENTIVE (asymmetry-blindness gap closed here)	~45%	MEDIUM-HIGH
3 NAME THE LEVEL AND WHY (bilateral/regional/minilateral/multilateral)	~55%	medium
4 CITE ONE VERIFIED INSTRUMENT WITH ITS EXACT STATUS AND DATE	~20%	***HIGHEST***
5 STATE THE OUTCOME SO FAR, SEPARATING ANNOUNCEMENT FROM IMPLEMENTATION	~25%	HIGH
6 NAME THE BINDING CONSTRAINT OR TRADE-OFF	~30%	***HIGHEST***
7 CALIBRATED WAY FORWARD (direction, never prediction)	~70%	medium
8 CLOSE BY RELATING BACK TO AUTONOMY OR THE NAMED INTEREST	~35%	HIGH

⚠ Read the middle column. The steps almost everyone attempts cannot discriminate between candidates. Steps 4 and 6 are the scoring steps precisely because they cannot be produced without preparation. Protect them in every time budget.

VII.2 The pre-writing 90 seconds

- 0-20s DIRECTIVE. Circle the verb. Discuss / Examine / Critically examine / Elucidate / Elaborate / Comment / Analyse / Assess. Write the required STRUCTURE in the margin before anything else.
- 20-40s PREMISE CHECK. Does the stem contain a factual error or a contestable characterisation? ("alliance", "replaced", "kingpin", "trade bloc"). If yes, plan ONE clause to restate it -- never a paragraph, never a confrontation.
- 40-60s INTEREST HEAD. Which of the seven? Write it down. It becomes the first line and the last line.
- 60-80s TWO ANCHORS. Choose exactly two dated instruments or data points. Write their DATES in the margin. If you cannot recall a date, choose a different anchor.
- 80-90s CONSTRAINT. Write one word: asymmetry / capacity / geography / rival-power / partner-politics / dependence. This is step 6, reserved in advance so it is never crowded out.

VII.3 The status-discipline rules (non-negotiable)

1. Every instrument gets a status word: proposed · adopted · signed · ratified · in force · delivered.
2. Every "in force" claim gets a scope clause: in force among whom.
3. Every figure gets a verb that matches it: allocated · earmarked · approved · disbursed · delivered.
4. Every participation claim gets a category and a date: member · partner country · observer · dialogue partner · guest, as of a date.
5. Every grouping gets a binding character: treaty alliance · non-treaty coalition · consultative forum.
6. Every doctrine gets a classification: vision · policy doctrine · programme · funded scheme.
7. Another state's unilateral measure is exposure, never an obligation on India.
8. If a claim cannot pass rules 1–7, it does not enter the answer.

VII.4 The five sentences that cost marks, and their replacements

✗ Costs marks	✓ Earns marks
"India and X enjoy warm and cordial relations."	"India's interest in X is primarily [head]; it is pursued at the [level] level."
"Several MoUs were signed, deepening cooperation."	"An MoU on [subject] was signed on [date]; as a statement of intent it is not self-executing, and implementation requires separate evidence."
"India should balance its relations with all major powers."	"India's posture is hedging — deep, simultaneous, non-exclusive engagement — evidenced by [dated item A] and [dated item B]."
"However, challenges remain."	"The binding constraint is [named constraint], evidenced by [dated instance]."
"India will emerge as a leading power in the coming decade."	"The calibrated course is to diversify across politically incompatible partners and to indigenise — measures that reduce, without eliminating, the price of autonomy."

VII.5 The 30-second final scan

- [] Is there at least ONE date in every substantive paragraph?
- [] Have I used the word "alliance" only where a mutual-defence obligation exists?
- [] Have I used "signed", "ratified" and "in force" correctly and distinctly?
- [] Is there a NAMED constraint, not a generic "challenges remain"?
- [] Does the way forward contain a DIRECTION and no PREDICTION?
- [] Have I written the words "will emerge", "will become" or "by 20XX"? Strike them.
- [] Does the last line return to the interest head or to autonomy?

PART VIII — FINAL RAPID REVISION MATRIX

VIII.1 Doctrine matrix

	Non-alignment	Strategic autonomy	Multi-alignment
World structure	Bipolar	Unipolar moment → multipolar	Multipolar
Core claim	Refuse bloc membership; judge on merit	Retain capacity to decide by own calculus	Belong prominently to opposed pairs
Method	Bloc avoidance + convening	Diversification + capability + refusal of imposed limits	Issue-based coalitions + portfolio management
Chief misreading	Neutrality	Equidistance	Joining everything
Chief cost	Western irritation; 1954 sequencing; 1962	Dependence risk; third-party pricing	Friction with every partner; "amoral"
The constant	Independent, interest-based decision-making	← same →	← same →

VIII.2 The 25-fact bank

Fact	Value
Panchsheel principles	5

Fact	Value
Panchsheel date and document	29 April 1954; preamble, India–China Agreement on Trade and Intercourse with the Tibet Region of China
Bandung Afro-Asian Conference	1955, called by India and the other Colombo powers
First non-aligned conference	Belgrade, 1961 — Nehru with Nasser and Tito
Asian Relations Conference	March 1947, New Delhi, before independence
Shanghai Communiqué	February 1972, US–China, based on the Five Principles
AFRICA Fund	Harare non-aligned summit, 1986
Nehru's non-alignment	Three elements: no bloc alliance · independent approach · friendly relations with all
Nehru on Israel policy	1958 — "not a matter of high principle ... balance of factors"
Rice on non-alignment	2007 — "irrelevant"; Mukherjee replied
Indira Gandhi in the US	1982 — "India stands upright!"
Sikri's Gulf diaspora	~5 million
Pillai Committee	Appointed June 1965; reported October 1966; 77 meetings; corps then 300; four weaknesses
IFS cadre increase	2008 — 520 (320 IFS + 200 support)
SAGAR	Mauritius, 12 March 2015
MAHASAGAR	Port Louis, 12 March 2025 — "going beyond SAGAR"; SAGAR reaffirmed
Voice of Global South Summits	3 — 12–13 Jan 2023 · 17 Nov 2023 · 17 Aug 2024, all virtual
BRICS partner-country category	Kazan, 24 October 2024
BIMSTEC Charter in force	20 May 2024
BIMSTEC Maritime Transport Agreement	Signed 3 Apr 2025; in force 16 May 2026 among Bhutan, India, Myanmar, Thailand
IMEC MoU	9 September 2023, eight signatories
BBNJ Agreement	In force 17 January 2026; India signed 25 September 2024, ratification not deposited
US–India Major Defense Partnership framework	Signed 31 October 2025 (ten-year)
India–Russia Annual Summit, 23rd	4–5 December 2025, New Delhi
Additional Russian-oil-linked US duty	Effective 27 August 2025; removed 7 February 2026

VIII.3 The 2026 current-affairs strip (10 Feb – 10 Aug 2026 window and immediate context)

Date	Item	Status class
17 Jan 2026	BBNJ Agreement enters into force; India a non-ratifying signatory	Treaty in force (pre-window context)
31 Jan 2026	Second India–Arab Foreign Ministers' Meeting, New Delhi; Delhi Declaration	Declaration — political (secondary; pre-window)

Date	Item	Status class
1 Feb 2026	Union Budget 2026-27: MEA ₹22,118 cr; neighbours ₹4,548 cr; Bhutan ₹2,288 cr; Bangladesh ₹60 cr; Chabahar nil	Allocation — input (secondary)
6 Feb 2026	India–US interim trade agreement framework announced	Framework, not a concluded treaty (secondary)
7 Feb 2026	Additional Russian-oil-linked US duty removed	Measure withdrawn
14 Feb 2026	62nd Munich Security Conference (13–15 Feb): "We are very much wedded to strategic autonomy"	Ministerial statement — fetched directly
5–7 Mar 2026	11th Raisina Dialogue, New Delhi — "Saṁskāra: Assertion, Accommodation, Advancement"	Conference (secondary)
Apr 2026	Fifth India–Bhutan Development Cooperation Talks: 12 PTA projects ₹332 cr (cumulative 82 projects, ₹6,860 cr); ₹4,000 cr concessional LoC; AIIMS–KGUMS MoU; 45 EVs handed over; two parks inaugurated	Mixed instruments (secondary)
Apr 2026 (reported 6 Jun)	Russian share of India's oil-import VALUE ~38%, an 11-month high; premium +425%	Data — fetched directly
14–15 May 2026	BRICS Foreign Ministers' Meeting, New Delhi, under India's chairship	Ministerial meeting (secondary)
?	No fourth Voice of Global South Summit · no verifiable BRICS Summit outcome · no in-window MAHASAGAR development	Absences — state them, do not fill them

VIII.4 The trap grid — one line each

✕ Trap	✓ Correction
Panchsheel at Bandung	29 April 1954, India–China Tibet-region trade agreement preamble
Six Panchsheel principles	Five; "equality and mutual benefit" is one
Article 51 mandates non-alignment	Non-justiciable DPSP; never mentions alignment; Art 51A = Fundamental Duties
Non-alignment = neutrality	USSR from 1954; Commonwealth; capital from both blocs
Policy = Movement	Principle survives relabelled; the Movement's salience narrowed
Strategic autonomy = equidistance	Deep and unequal with several, simultaneously
Strategic autonomy = costless	27 Aug 2025 → 7 Feb 2026; then a 425% premium
Multi-alignment = joining everything	Most listed platforms are non-treaty; India declines what binds
Hedging = fence-sitting	The hedger occupies every row; the fence-sitter none
Quad = alliance / Asian NATO	Non-treaty coalition; no mutual-defence obligation
Partner country = member	Kazan, 24 Oct 2024; participation without membership rights
Chairship = authority to bind	Agenda and process anchor only
MAHASAGAR replaced SAGAR	"Going beyond"; SAGAR reaffirmed for the Indian Ocean region
SAGAR/MAHASAGAR = treaties	Declared visions

✕ Trap	✓ Correction
India is a party to BBNJ	Signed 25 Sep 2024; ratification not deposited
Charter/agreement "in force for all"	State the depositing parties
MoU = agreement	Statement of intent; not self-executing
Corridor MoU = operating corridor	Route conception → MoU → financed segment → commissioned segment
Line of credit = grant = delivery	Three different things
Allocation = expenditure	Appropriation only
Framework announced = treaty concluded	Two different stages
Another state's sanction = obligation on India	Exposure and secondary risk
Fourth VOGSS	Three verified editions; state the absence
Cold-War history in a GS-II IR answer	Chronology-substitution gap; World History owns it
"Challenges remain" as balance	Name the constraint and date the instance

VIII.5 The seven-line exit summary

1. One principle, three labels: independent, interest-based decision-making, expressed as non-alignment, then strategic autonomy, then multi-alignment.
2. Seven interest heads: security, growth, resources, technology, diaspora, reputation, rule-shaping.
3. Five-stage chain plus two: interest → context → instrument → outcome → constraint → calibrated way forward → close on autonomy.
4. Six rungs of bindingness, and a separate delivery axis. Never upgrade either.
5. Balancing against · bandwagoning with · hedging both. Equidistance is not a posture.
6. Concede what the evidence supports — capacity, dependence, normative inconsistency — and qualify the rest.
7. Recommend directions; never predict outcomes. And when a fact cannot be verified, say so.

Workbook completion record

Requirement	Status
Explicit PYQ ownership audit with stated method	✓ Part I, five-step method
Directly topic-owned Mains PYQs	✓ Zero — stated honestly for GS-II 2018–2025 (160 questions examined)
Directly topic-owned Prelims PYQs	✓ Zero verifiable — stated honestly for GS-I 2018–2026, with the 2026 image-only-key limitation disclosed
Closest verified application PYQs, clearly separated, owning topic named	✓ 8 Mains + 2 Prelims, each with its true owning topic file
Mains PYQ treatment: exact question, year/paper/Q/marks/words, ownership label, demand-decoding table, model answer, top-answer requirements, skeleton and timing, common mistakes	✓ All 8
Prelims PYQ treatment: exact question and options, year and set, verified official key, option-by-option explanation, topic relevance, trap logic	✓ Both, keys verified from Ans-2025-GS1.pdf
Questions with unverifiable keys omitted rather than answered	✓ 2026 GS-I Q64 and Q78 omitted, with the reason stated

Requirement	Status
Exactly 32 original hard MCQs, static + current application	✓ 32
Strict A → B → C → D × 8 rotation	✓ Verified in the key table: 8A, 8B, 8C, 8D, no consecutive repeats
Four plausible options, detailed explanation and trap logic per MCQ	✓ 32 / 32
Remedial practice: classification/status errors	✓ Part V.1 — three drills
Remedial practice: current-affairs overclaiming	✓ Part V.2 — three drills, including the four-question filter
Exactly 10 original solved Mains questions, 3 × 10 / 4 × 15 / 3 × 20	✓ O-1 to O-10
Demand decoding, model answer and top-answer checklist for each	✓ 10 / 10
GS-II IR high-score answer protocol	✓ Part VII
Final rapid revision matrix	✓ Part VIII
Fabrication check	✓ No invented PYQ, no invented key, no invented summit or outcome; contested reporting flagged with ?